Learning to generate

Autoencoders, VAEs and GANs, built from one handwritten 3



A 3 turns into a 7. Every frame is decoded from a point on a straight line through the code space of the VAE we train today.

Nipun Batra · IIT Gandhinagar

START WITH A QUESTION

Who are these people?



No one. Each face is a random vector of 512 numbers pushed through a trained network.

Karras, Laine & Aila, *A Style-Based Generator Architecture for GANs* (StyleGAN), 2019 · CC BY-NC 4.0

YOUR TURN TO BE THE JUDGE

Real or generated?



Six are MNIST test digits, six come from a network. Write down which six are fake.

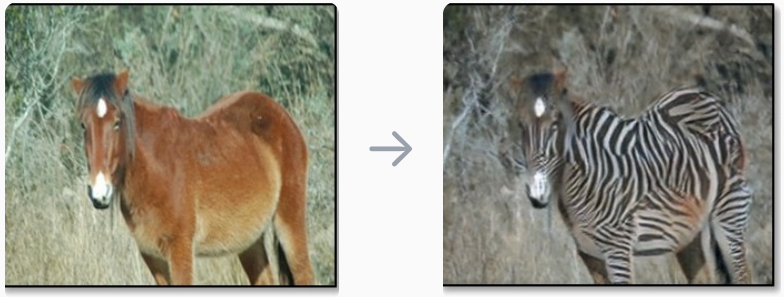
GENERATION IS NOT ONLY "MAKE A RANDOM PICTURE"

Predict the output, then look

a sketch → a photo



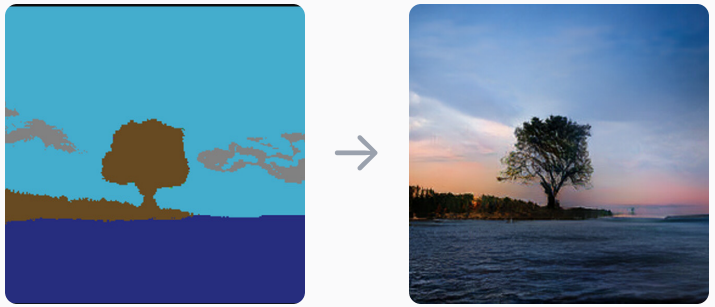
a horse → a zebra



fill a hole



a label map → a landscape



> Each input allows many plausible outputs. A generator must pick one that looks real.

pix2pix (Isola et al. 2017) · CycleGAN (Zhu et al. 2017) · Context Encoders (Pathak et al. 2016) · SPADE (Park et al. 2019). All published model outputs.

ONE INPUT, MANY ANSWERS

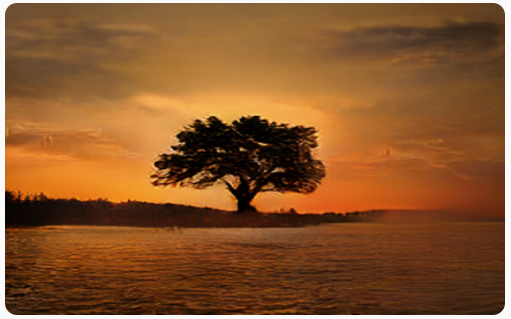
The same label map, three different photographs



the condition



sample 1



sample 2



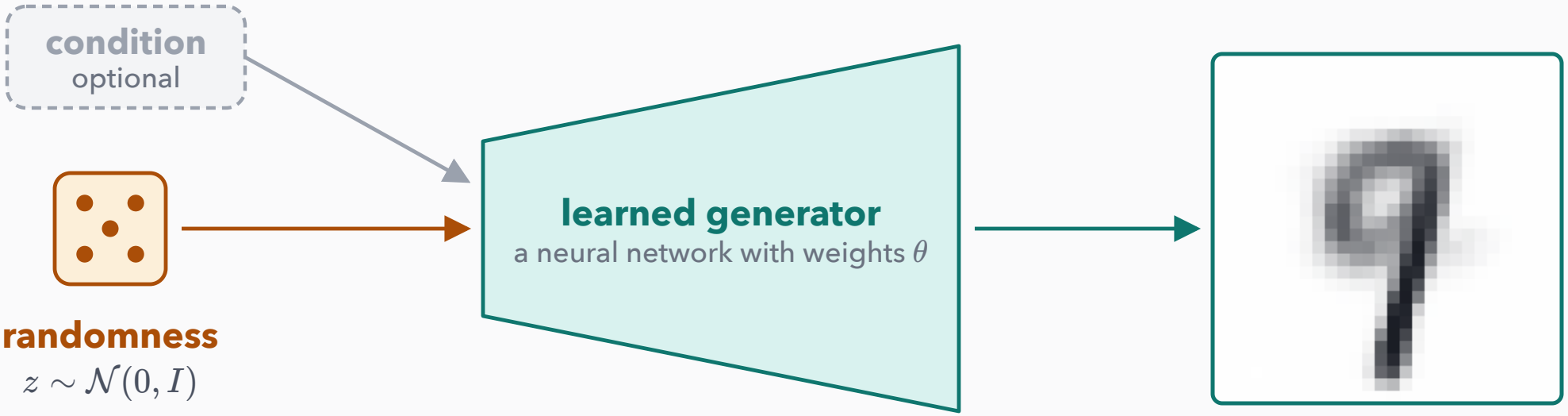
sample 3

A generator does not learn one answer. It learns a distribution of answers and draws from it.

SPADE / GauGAN, Park et al. 2019, teaser figure: here the variation comes from a style image given to the generator.

WHAT ALL OF THESE SHARE

Randomness in, a learned network, a sample out



e.g. a sketch, a label, a sentence

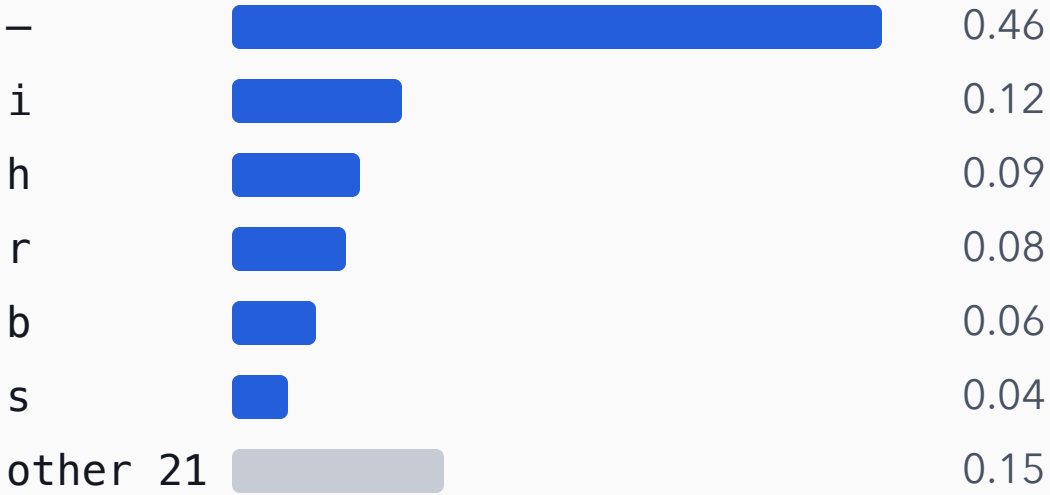
Training means: adjust θ until the samples look like the data. But what is the loss?

PART 1 OF THIS COURSE

You have already built a generator

Our name model reads three characters and gives a probability for every next character.

after `a a b`, the trained model says:



Generate: sample a character, append it, repeat.



A different random draw at any step gives a different name. That is a generative model: it gives probabilities, and we sample from them.

Same idea today: learn a distribution, then sample from it. Only now the samples are images.

PART 1 OF THIS COURSE

A whole name gets one probability

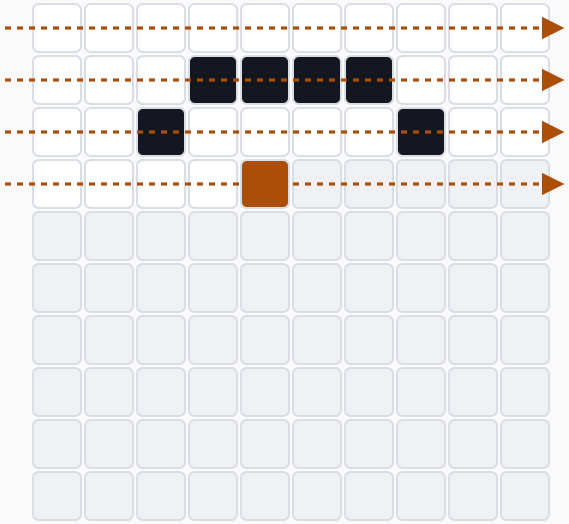
context	next	probability	−log p
– – –	a	0.08	2.53
– – a	a	0.08	2.53
– a a	b	0.02	3.91
a a b	i	0.12	2.12
a b i	d	0.09	2.41
b i d	–	0.23	1.47
aabid		**3.2×10^{-7}**	**14.96**

$$p_\theta(\text{aabid}) = \prod_t p_\theta(x_t \mid x_{<t}) \qquad -\log p_\theta(\text{aabid}) = \sum_t -\log p_\theta(x_t \mid x_{<t})$$

> **Training made this number large for every name in the data. That is maximum likelihood, and it is what we want for images too.**

Two ways to generate a 28 × 28 digit

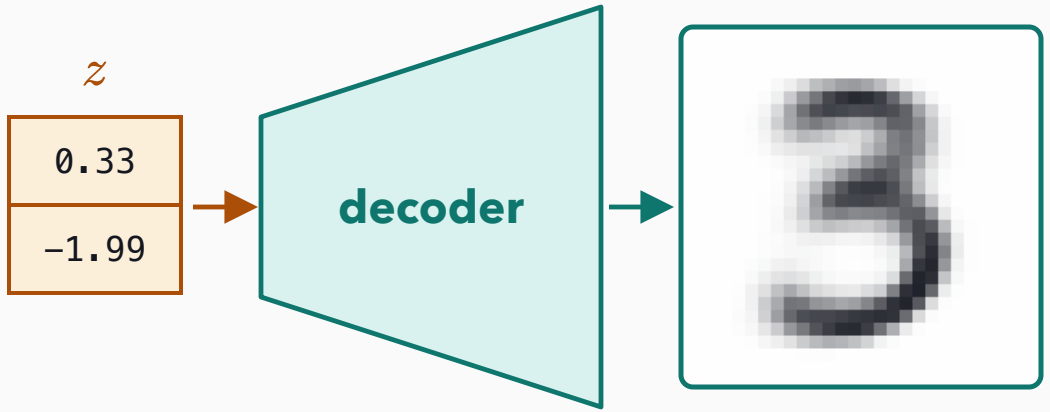
A · one pixel at a time



784 predictions in a row, like our names

$$p(x) = \prod_i p(x_i \mid x_{<i})$$

B · all pixels from one random vector



one pass: 2 numbers in, 784 pixels out

$$x = \text{decoder}(z)$$

Today: route B. Two questions: where does z come from, and how do we train a decoder when no one tells us the right z?

THE PLAN

Today's route

1. **Distributions and hidden causes** on a 1-D toy dataset
2. **Autoencoders** and why they cannot generate
3. **KL divergence** how far apart are two distributions?
4. **The ELBO** a loss for a model we cannot evaluate exactly
5. **Reparameterisation** backprop through a random draw
6. **The VAE on MNIST** one digit, end to end, with real numbers
7. **GANs** learn the judge instead of the likelihood

> **One running image throughout: test digit #90, a handwritten 3.**

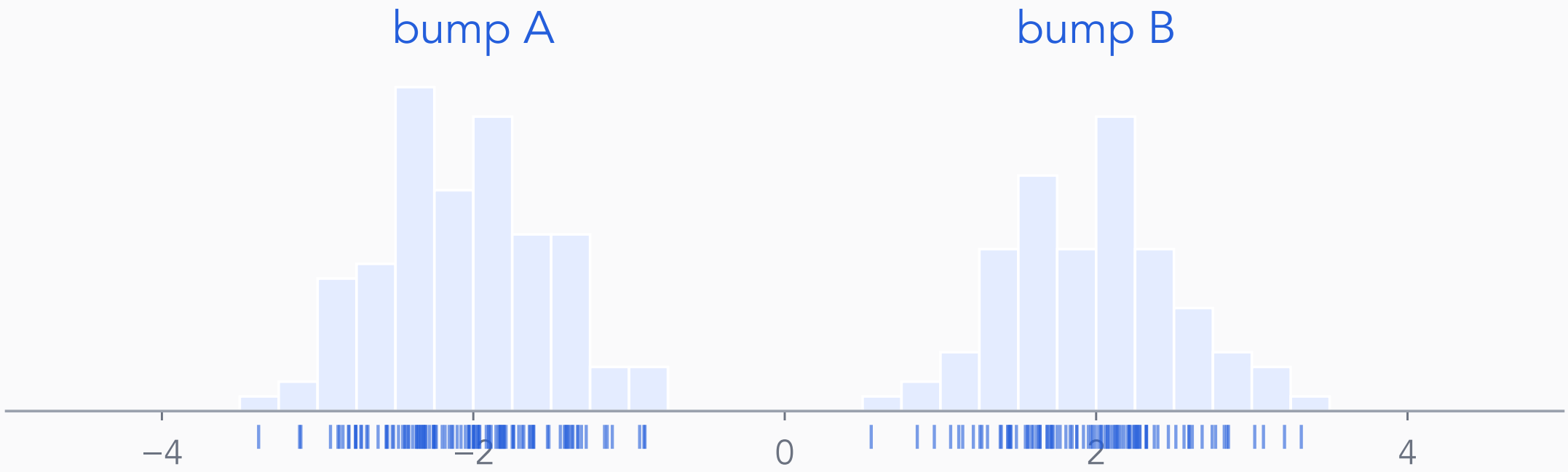
PART 1

What does it mean to learn a distribution?

Before images, one number. Everything we need (fitting, sampling, hidden causes, inference) fits on a number line.

OUR 1-D TOY DATA

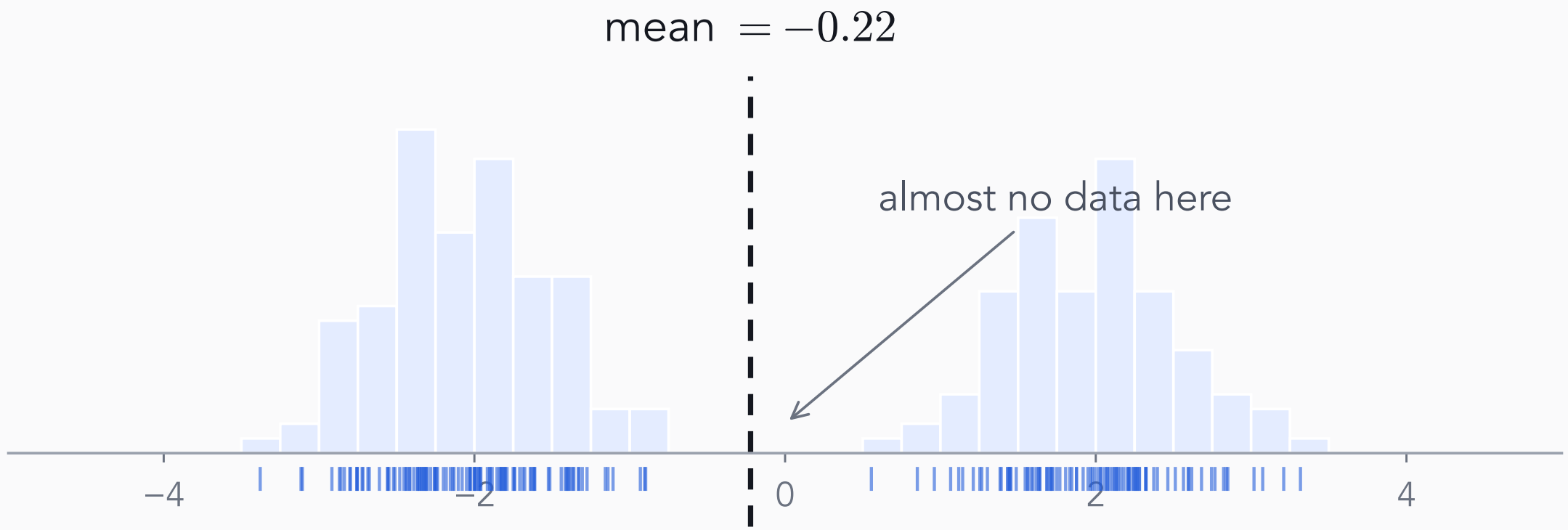
200 numbers in two clumps



> **Pretend each number is an image squashed to one value. How would you produce a 201st that looks like it belongs?**

A TEMPTING ANSWER

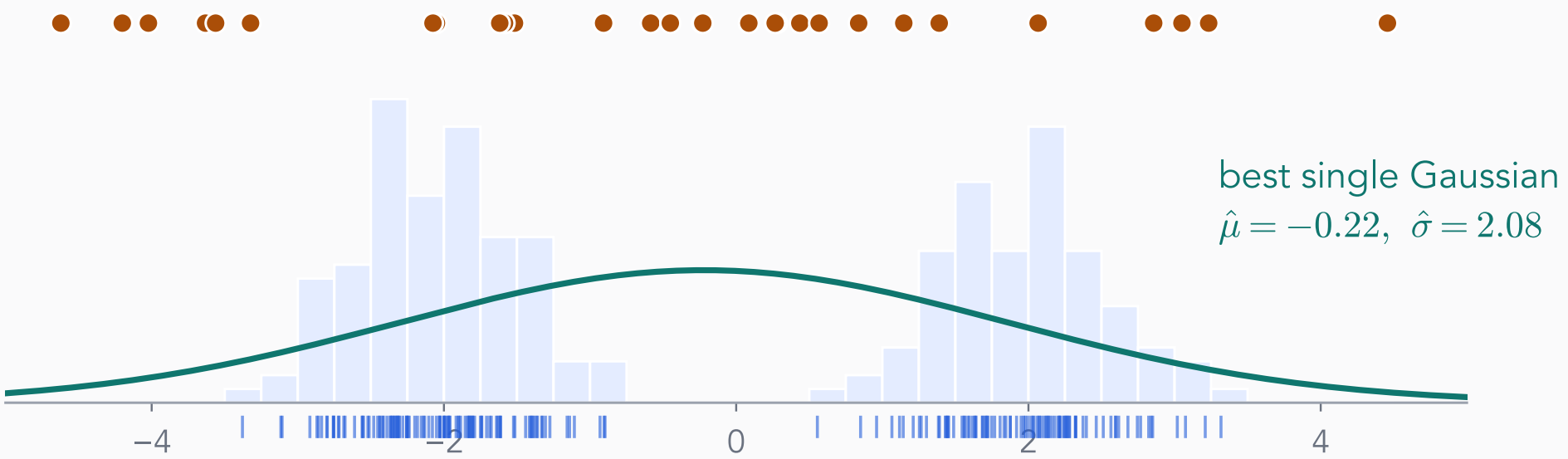
The average is a terrible sample



A model that predicts the mean always outputs something that never occurs. Regression thinking does not give generation.

FIT, THEN SAMPLE

The best single Gaussian, by maximum likelihood

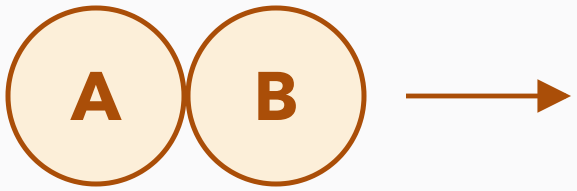


$$\hat{\mu} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} x_i = -0.22 \qquad \hat{\sigma}^2 = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}(x_i - \hat{\mu})^2 = 4.31 \qquad x_{\text{new}} = \hat{\mu} + \hat{\sigma}\,\varepsilon, \quad \varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1)$$

11 of 30 samples land in the empty gap. Best fit within the family, wrong shape.

Hidden choice first, then the number

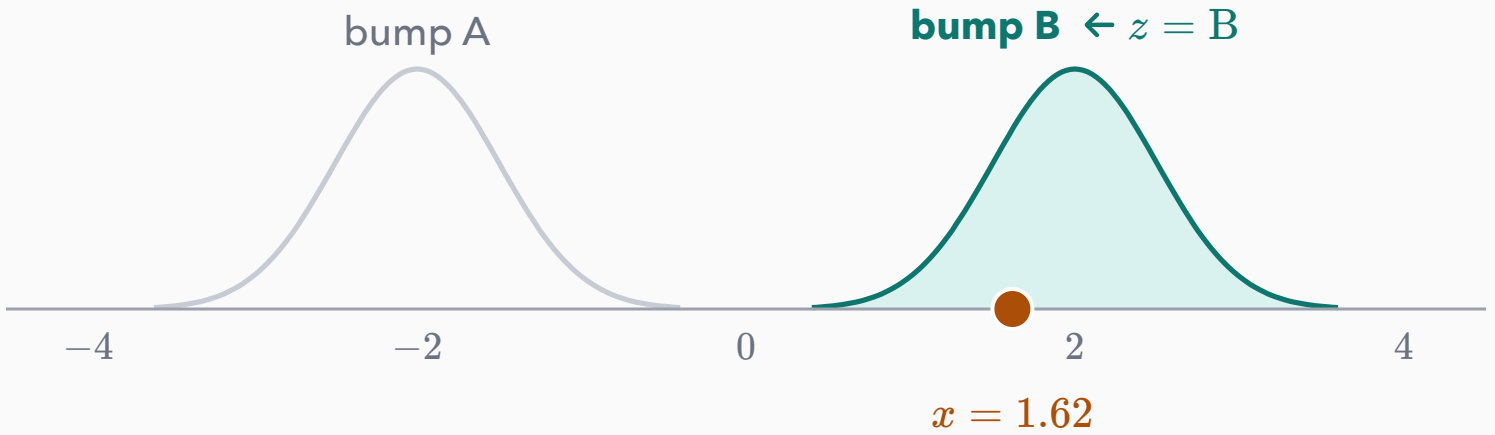
step 1 · hidden choice



flip a fair coin:

$p(z{=}\mathrm{A}) = p(z{=}\mathrm{B}) = \frac{1}{2}$

step 2 · draw x from the chosen bump



> The coin is never written down in the data. We only ever see x. The coin z is a hidden (latent) variable.

ONE INGREDIENT, WORKED BY HAND

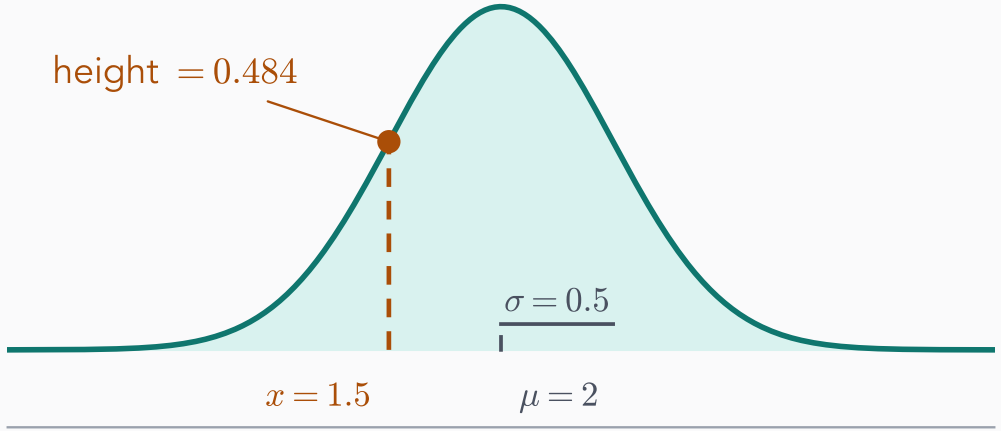
How high is bump B at $x = 1.5$?

$$\mathcal{N}(x;\mu,\sigma^2) = \frac{1}{\sigma\sqrt{2\pi}}\exp\Big(-\frac{(x-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}\Big)$$

$$\frac{x-\mu}{\sigma} = \frac{1.5-2}{0.5} = -1$$

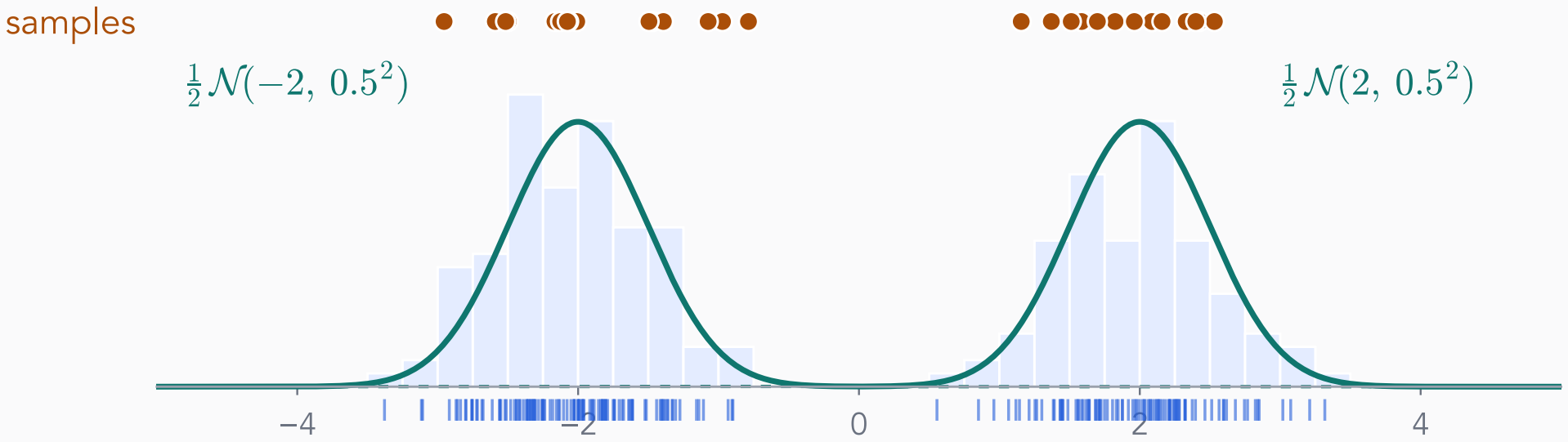
$$\exp\Big(-\tfrac{1}{2}\cdot(-1)^2\Big) = e^{-0.5} = 0.607$$

$$\frac{1}{0.5\sqrt{2\pi}} = 0.798 \qquad \Rightarrow \qquad 0.798 \times 0.607 = \mathbf{0.484}$$



> A density is a height, not a probability: it can exceed 1 for a narrow bump. Only areas are probabilities.

To score x, add over every hidden value



$$p(x) = \sum_{z \in \{\mathrm{A},\mathrm{B}\}} p(z)\, p(x \mid z) = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathcal{N}(x; -2, 0.5^2) + \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathcal{N}(x;\ 2, 0.5^2)$$

$$\text{at } x = 1.5: \quad \tfrac{1}{2} \cdot 0.000 + \tfrac{1}{2} \cdot 0.484 = 0.242$$

> **Samples now fall in the bumps. Remember this sum. With images it becomes an integral we cannot compute.**

RUN THE STORY BACKWARDS

You see $x = 0.1$. Which bump made it?

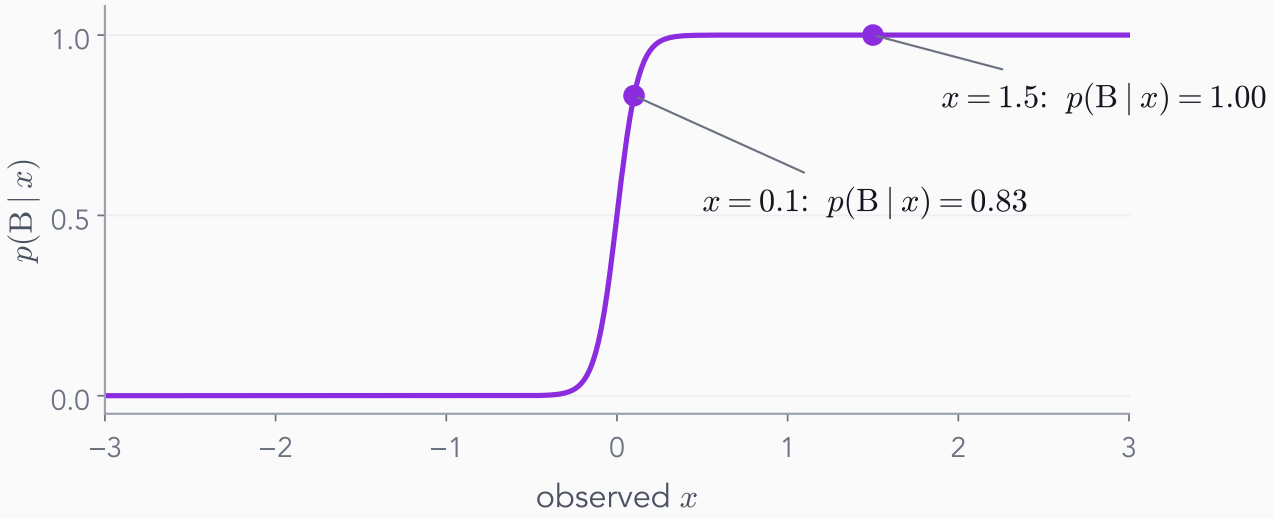
bump z	prior $p(z)$	likelihood $p(x \mid z)$	prior × likelihood	÷ total = posterior
A, centre -2	0.5	1.18×10^{-4}	5.89×10^{-5}	0.168
B, centre 2	0.5	5.84×10^{-4}	2.92×10^{-4}	**0.832**
total $= p(x)$			3.51×10^{-4}	**1.000**

$$p(\mathrm{B} \mid x) = \frac{p(\mathrm{B})\, p(x \mid \mathrm{B})}{p(x)} = 0.832$$

Bayes' rule is just this table: multiply, then divide by the total. $x = 0.1$ is close to the middle, so we stay unsure.

DO IT FOR EVERY x

The posterior, as a curve



Repeat the table for every x and plot $p(\mathrm{B} \mid x)$.

Far right: certainly B. Far left: certainly A. Near 0: unsure.

For these two bumps the curve is exactly $\mathrm{sigmoid}(16x)$: a logistic regression in disguise.

> **Going from an observation back to its hidden cause is called inference. The VAE's encoder will learn to do it.**

FOUR WORDS WE WILL USE ALL LECTURE

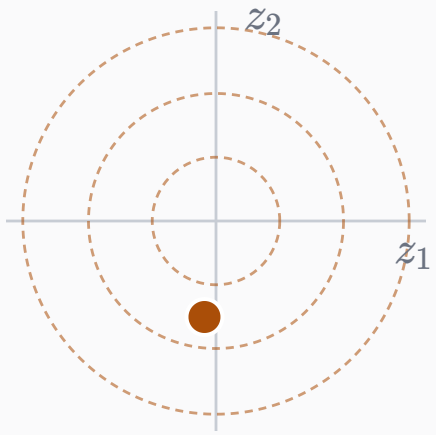
Prior, likelihood, evidence, posterior

name	symbol	question it answers	at $x = 0.1$
prior	$p(z)$	what do we believe about z before seeing x?	0.5, 0.5
likelihood	$p(x \mid z)$	if z were known, how probable is this x?	5.84×10^{-4} for B
evidence	$p(x)$	how probable is x overall, summing over z?	3.51×10^{-4}
posterior	$p(z \mid x)$	having seen x, which z explains it?	B: 0.832

Bayes ties them together: posterior = prior × likelihood ÷ evidence.

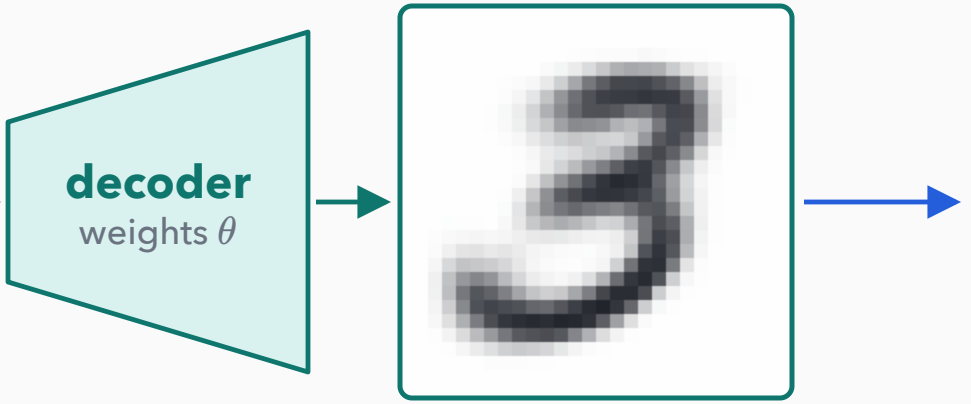
The same story for images

1 · draw a code



$$z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I), \quad z = (-0.18,\ -1.50)$$

2 · decode probabilities



$$\pi = \text{sigmoid}(\text{decoder}(z))$$

3 · flip each pixel



$$x_i \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_i)$$

> The code is 2 real numbers instead of a coin, and a network maps it to 784 pixel probabilities. Nobody tells it what z means.

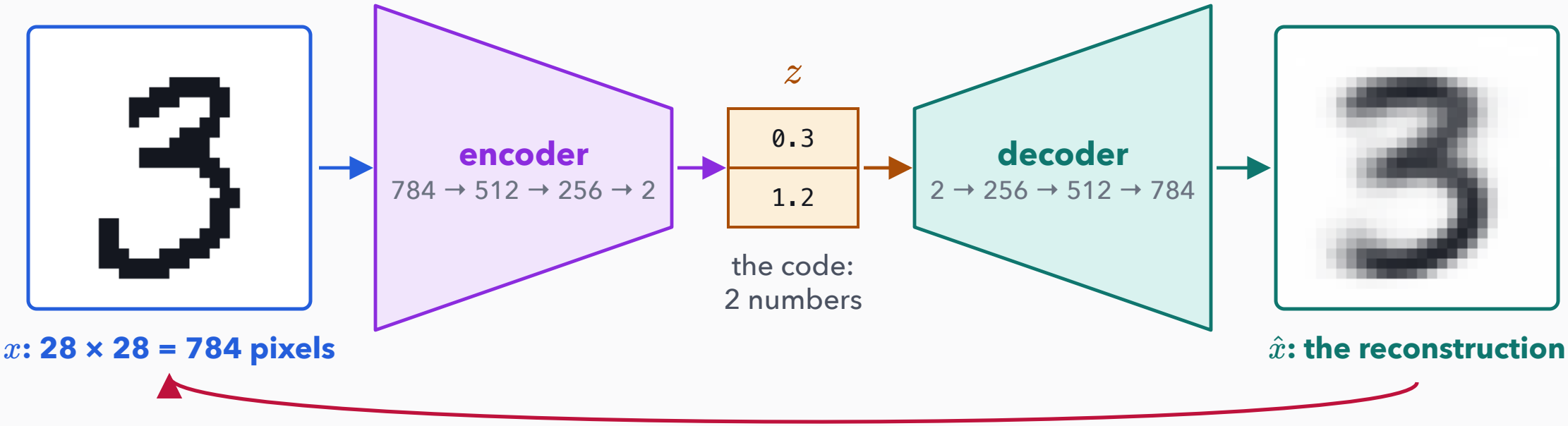
PART 2

First attempt: an autoencoder

Compress an image into a few numbers, then rebuild it. Then we try to generate with it, and watch that fail.

SQUEEZE, THEN REBUILD

An autoencoder on our 3



> No labels needed: the image is its own target. The 2 numbers in the middle are all the decoder gets.

COMPARING THE REBUILD WITH THE ORIGINAL

Binary cross-entropy, one pixel at a time

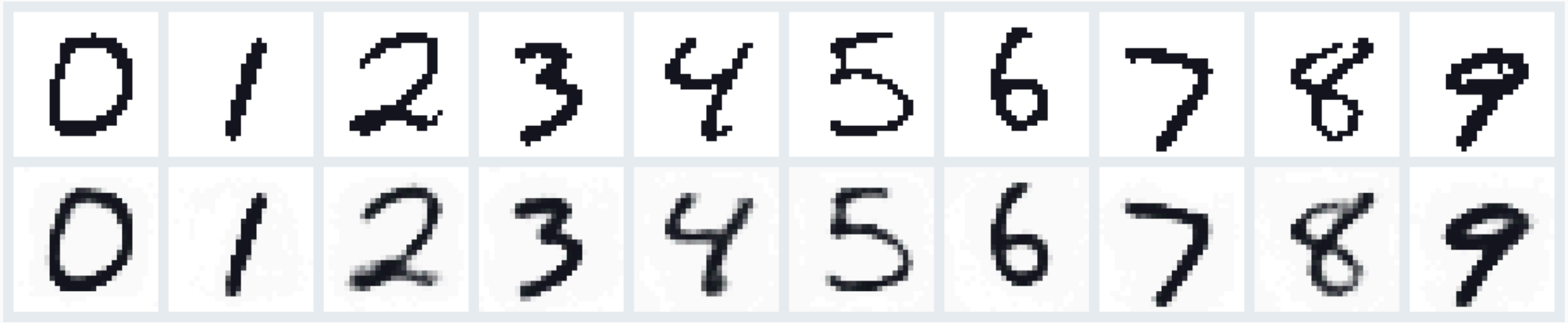
$$\text{loss}(x, \hat{x}) = -\sum_{i=1}^{784} \Big[x_i \log \hat{x}_i + (1 - x_i) \log(1 - \hat{x}_i) \Big]$$

pixel	true value	predicted	loss
ink, predicted well	1	0.90	$-\log 0.90 = 0.11$
paper, predicted well	0	0.10	$-\log 0.90 = 0.11$
ink, missed	1	0.20	$-\log 0.20 = 1.61$

Pixels are 0 or 1 here (we binarise MNIST). Later we will see this is exactly a log-likelihood.

TRAINED ON 60,000 DIGITS

It reconstructs very well



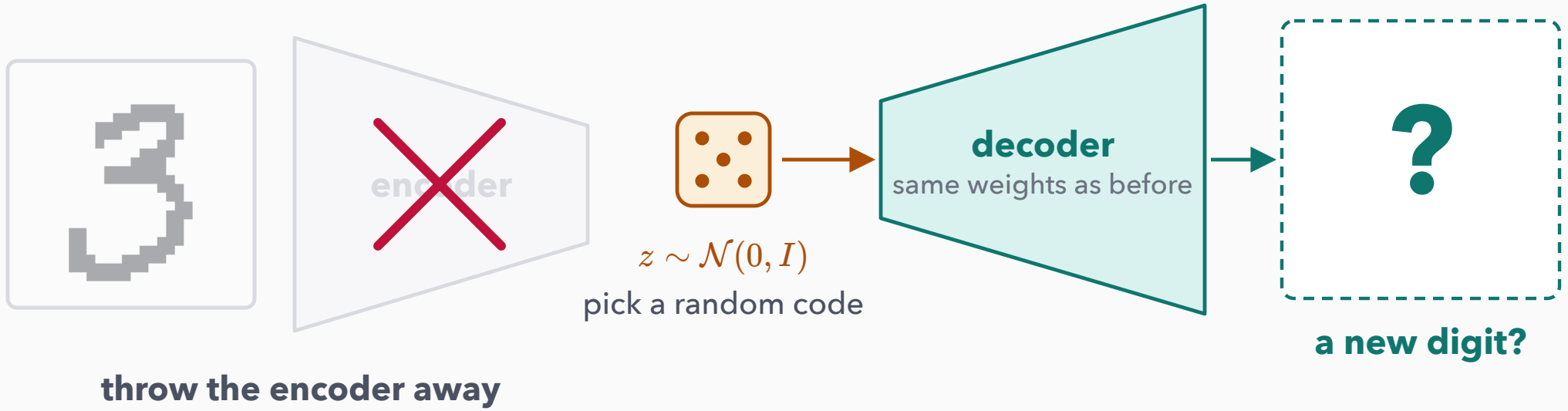
top: test digits it never saw

bottom: decoded from a 16-number code

784 pixels squeezed into 16 numbers and back. Average loss 44.9 nats per image. Can we now make new digits?

THE OBVIOUS IDEA

Keep the decoder, feed it a random code



The decoder turns codes into digits. So a random code should give a random digit. Right?

WHAT ACTUALLY COMES OUT

Random codes give scribbles

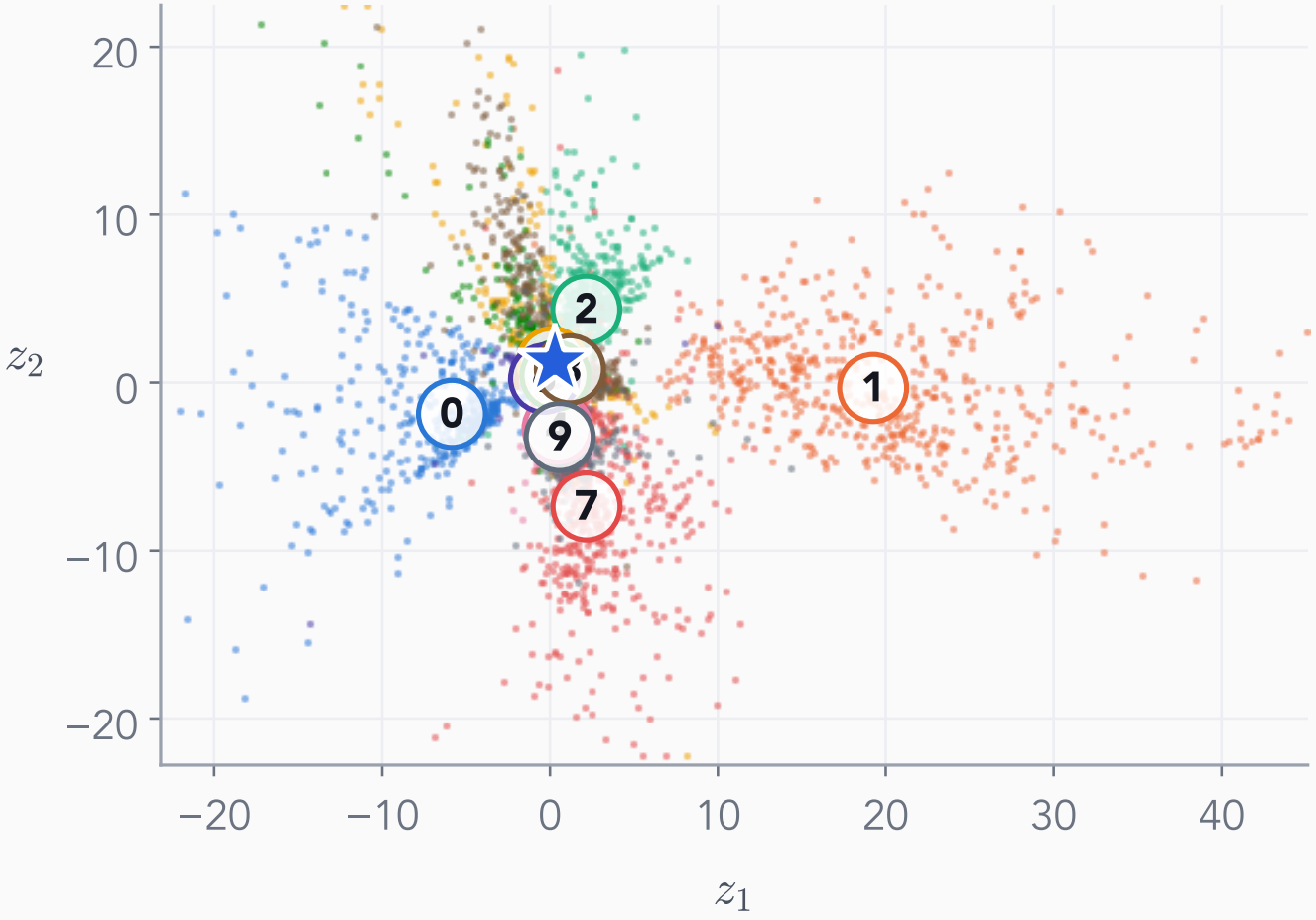


ten codes drawn from $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$ in 16 dimensions, through the trained decoder

The decoder only ever saw codes made by the encoder. Where do those codes live?

LOOK INSIDE (2-NUMBER VERSION)

Where 5,000 test digits land



Each dot is one test digit's code, coloured by its true label. The star is our 3.

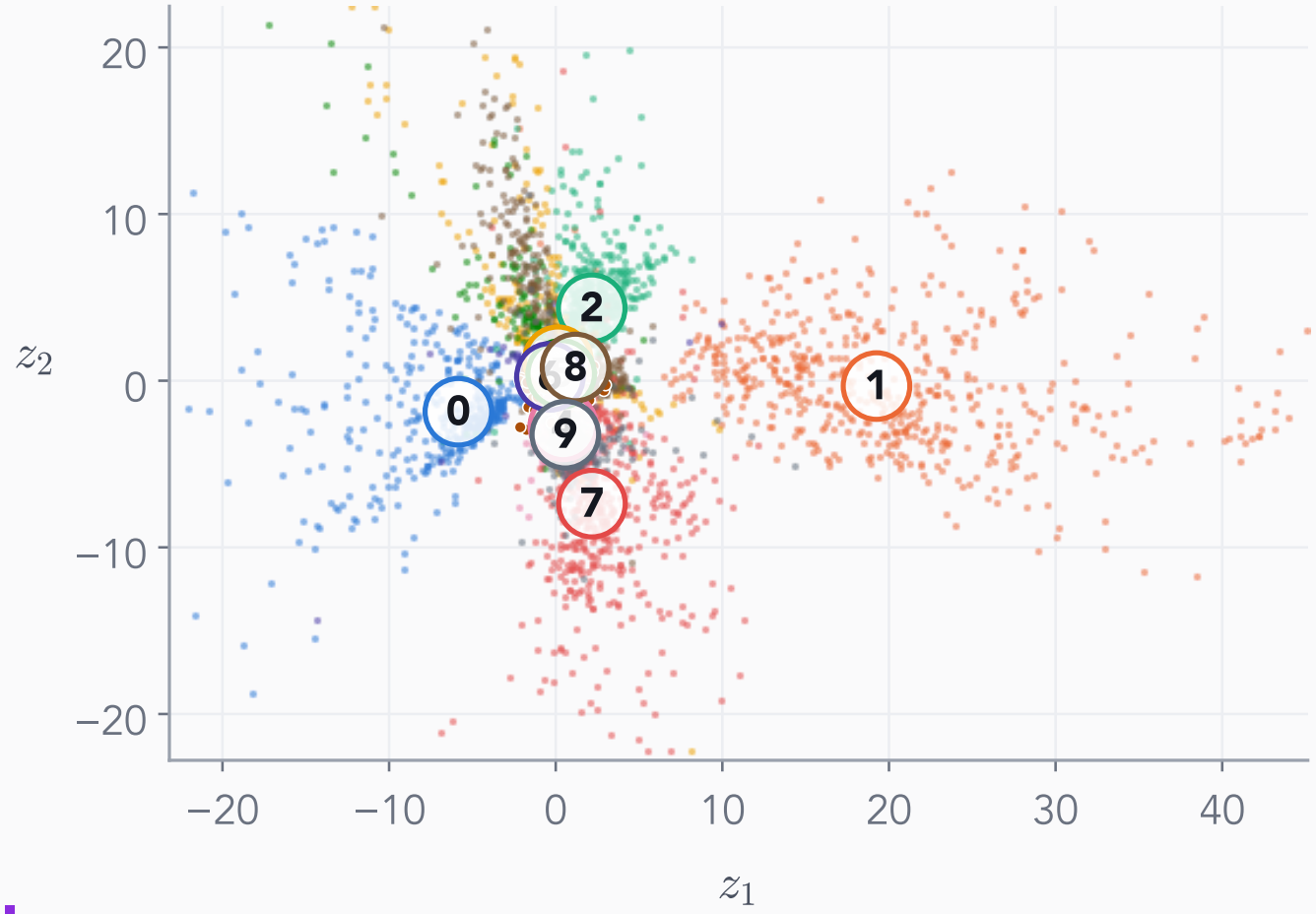
Same digits cluster together. Nobody asked for that; it just helps reconstruction.

Look at the axes: z_1 runs from −18.5 to 40.4. The dashed circles mark where $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$ puts its samples.

The code space has an arbitrary shape, scale and position.

OVERLAY RANDOM CODES

Random draws all land in one small spot



150 draws from $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$ in amber: all inside one tiny crowded patch.



ten of them decoded: some digits, some smudges

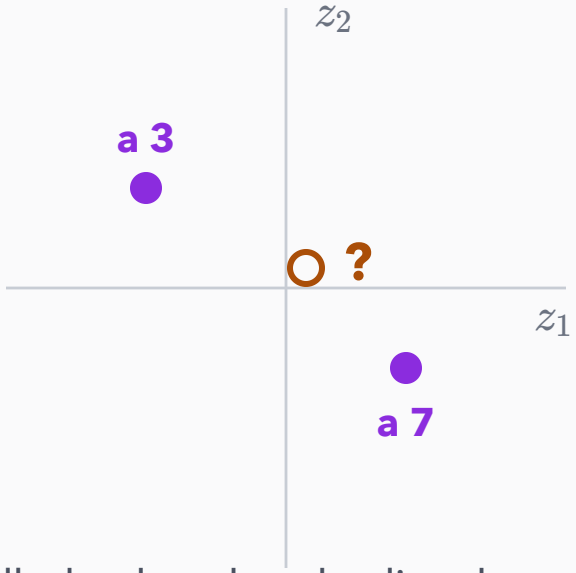
And we can never generate a 1: the 1s live near $z_1 \approx 20$.

To sample, we need to know where the codes are, and every point there must decode to something sensible.

WHAT WE WANT INSTEAD

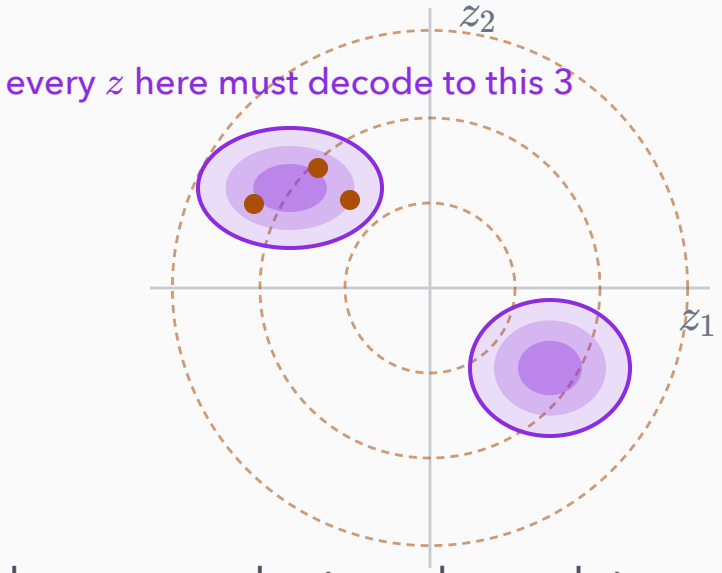
Encode to a cloud, not a point

autoencoder: a point



nothing tells the decoder what lives between codes

VAE: a cloud



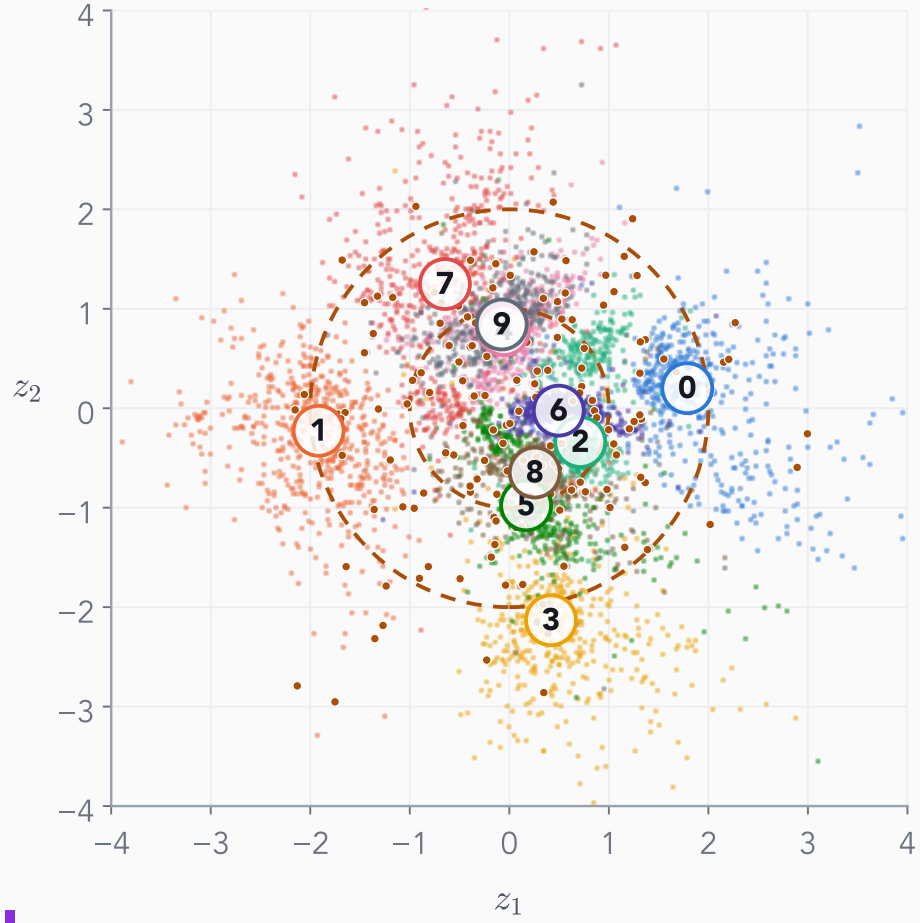
codes are spread out, overlap, and stay near $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$

Known: pull every cloud towards $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$, so random draws land on real codes.

Smooth: every point in a cloud must decode to that image, so neighbourhoods are meaningful.

A PREVIEW OF WHERE WE ARE GOING

The same plot for a VAE



Same data, same 2-number code, same random draws. Now the codes sit inside $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$.



the same kind of random codes, decoded

To get here we need two tools: a distance between distributions (KL), and a principled loss (the ELBO).

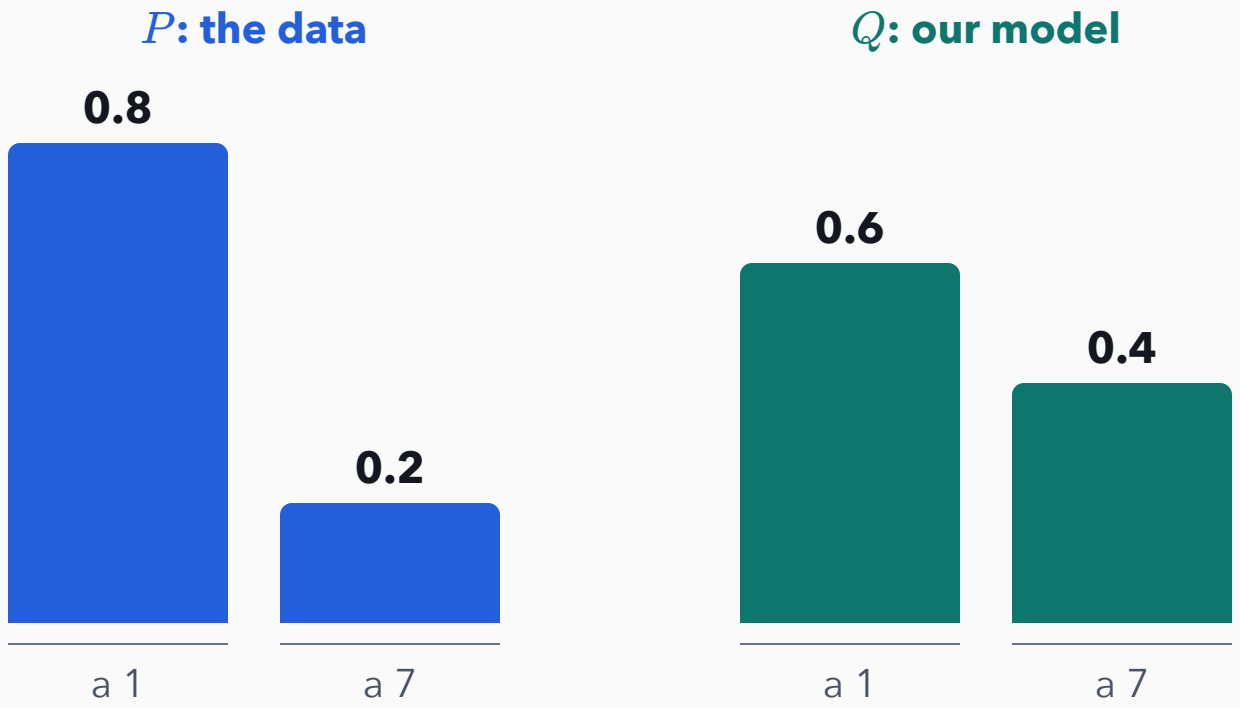
PART 3 · TOOL 1

KL divergence: how far is one distribution from another?

We need a number for "this cloud is far from $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$". Build it from surprise, with two bars first.

TWO DISTRIBUTIONS OVER THE SAME TWO OUTCOMES

The data says 80/20. The model says 60/40.



A dataset of 1s and 7s, 80% 1s. The model believes 60/40. How wrong is it, as one number?

INGREDIENT: SURPRISE

Surprise $= -\log(\text{probability})$

outcome	P	Q	surprise if you believe P	surprise if you believe Q
a 1	0.8	0.6	$-\log 0.8 = 0.223$	$-\log 0.6 = 0.511$
a 7	0.2	0.4	$-\log 0.2 = 1.609$	$-\log 0.4 = 0.916$

Certain events cost 0. Rare events cost a lot. Natural logs, so the unit is the **nat**.

Believing Q, a 1 surprises us more than it should (0.511 vs 0.223), a 7 less (0.916 vs 1.609).

KL, STEP 1 OF 3

For each outcome: how much extra surprise does Q cause?

$$\underbrace{-\log Q_i}_{\text{surprise under } Q} - \underbrace{(-\log P_i)}_{\text{surprise under } P} = \log \frac{P_i}{Q_i}$$

outcome	$-\log Q_i$	$-\log P_i$	extra surprise $\log(P_i/Q_i)$
a 1	0.511	0.223	$0.511 - 0.223 = 0.288$
a 7	0.916	1.609	$0.916 - 1.609 = -0.693$

Negative for the 7: Q over-predicts 7s, so a 7 surprises it less than it should.

KL, STEP 2 OF 3

Weight each outcome by how often it really happens

outcome	how often: P_i	extra surprise	weighted: $P_i \log(P_i/Q_i)$
a 1	0.8	0.288	$0.8 \times 0.288 = 0.230$
a 7	0.2	-0.693	$0.2 \times (-0.693) = -0.139$

Real data is 80% 1s, so the 1 row counts four times as much as the 7 row.

KL, STEP 3 OF 3

Add them up: that is the KL divergence

$$\mathrm{KL}(P \,\|\, Q) \;=\; \sum_i P_i \log \frac{P_i}{Q_i}$$

$$= 0.230 + (-0.139) = 0.092 \text{ nats}$$

One row was negative, yet the total can never be: $\mathrm{KL} \geq 0$.

$\mathrm{KL} = 0$ only when $Q = P$ exactly.

KL is the average extra surprise you pay for believing Q when the truth is P.

NOTATION WE WILL USE ALL LECTURE

$\mathbb{E}$ means "average over"

$$\mathbb{E}_{x\sim P}\big[f(x)\big] = \sum_{x} P(x)\, f(x)$$

exact, for a sum over outcomes

$$\mathbb{E}_{z\sim q}\big[f(z)\big] = \int q(z)\, f(z)\, dz$$

exact, for a continuous variable

$$\mathbb{E}_{x\sim P}\big[f(x)\big] \approx \frac{1}{S}\sum_{s=1}^{S} f(x_s), \quad x_s \sim P$$

estimated from samples

KL is an average: $\mathbf{KL}(P\|Q) = \mathbb{E}_{x\sim P}\big[\log \frac{P(x)}{Q(x)}\big]$. Five draws 1, 1, 7, 1, 1 give $\frac{1}{5}(4 \times 0.288 - 0.693) = 0.092$.

NOT A DISTANCE

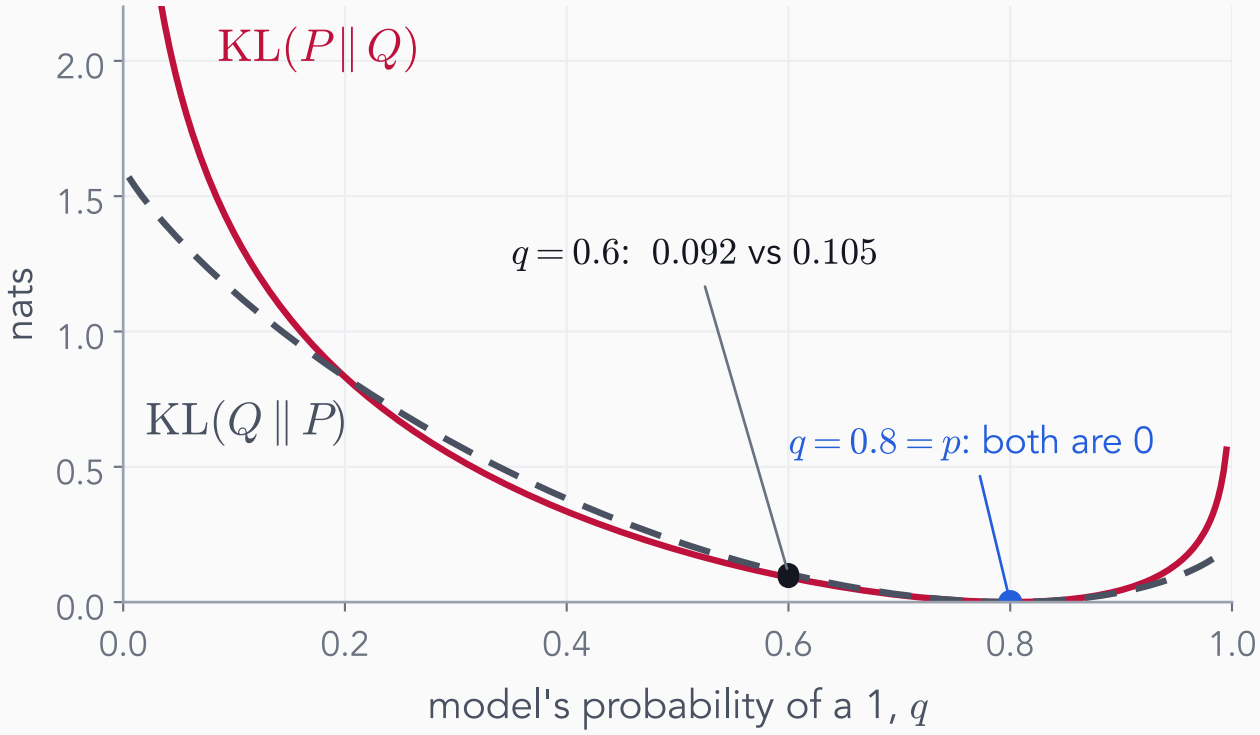
Swap the arguments, get a different number

$$\mathrm{KL}(Q\|P) = 0.6\log\frac{0.6}{0.8} + 0.4\log\frac{0.4}{0.2}$$

$$= -0.173 + 0.277 = 0.105$$

$0.105 \neq 0.092$: KL is not symmetric. "How wrong is Q about P" differs from "how wrong is P about Q".

Push $q \to 0$ and $\mathrm{KL}(P\|Q) \to \infty$. Never give zero probability to something that happens.



YOU HAVE MINIMISED A KL MANY TIMES

Cross-entropy = entropy + KL

$$H(P, Q) = -\sum_i P_i \log Q_i$$

cross-entropy: the loss you train classifiers with

$$= -\sum_i P_i \log P_i + \sum_i P_i \big(\log P_i - \log Q_i \big)$$

add and subtract $\sum_i P_i \log P_i$

$$= \underbrace{H(P)}_{\text{entropy: fixed by the data}} + \mathrm{KL}(P \,\|\, Q)$$

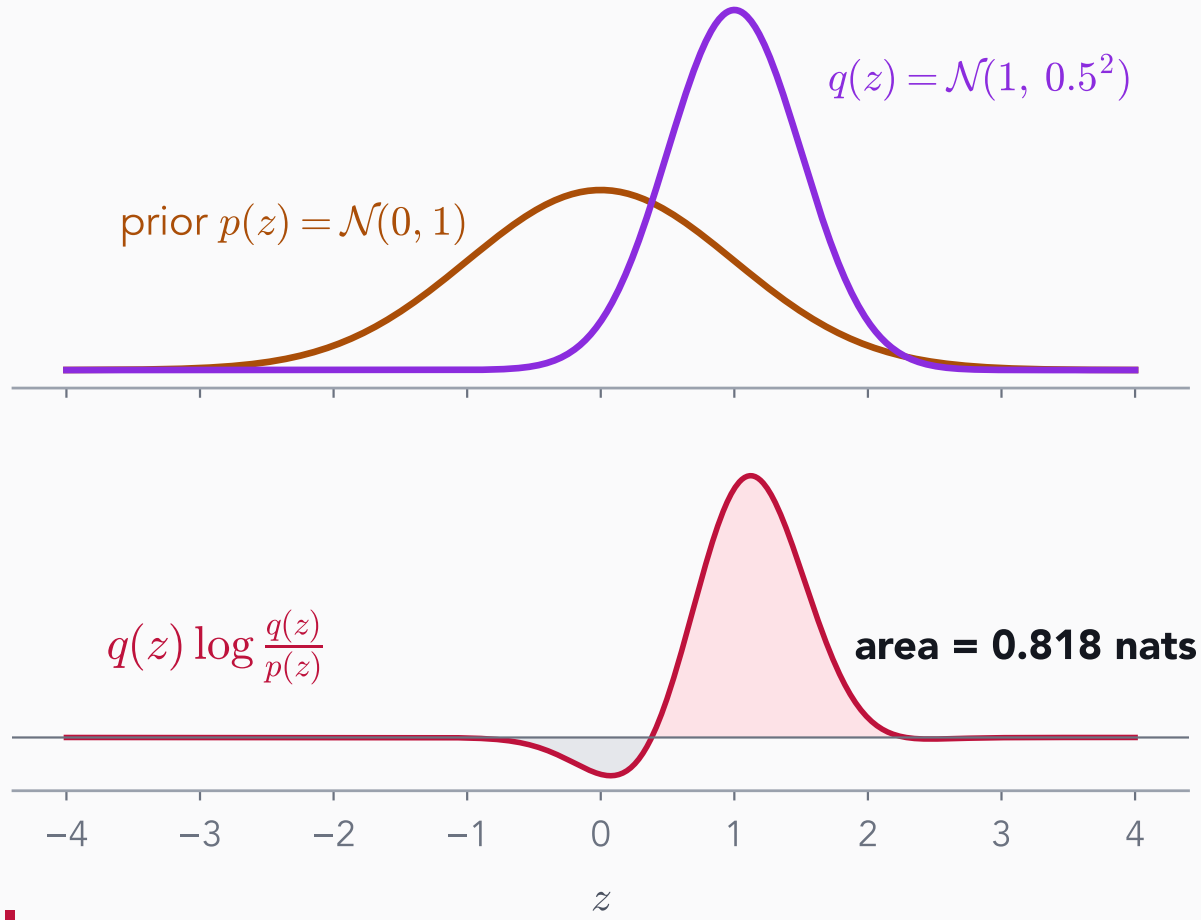
$H(P) = 0.500$
does not depend on the model

0.092
KL

Lowering cross-entropy can only lower the KL part. So does maximum likelihood: it minimises $\mathrm{KL}(\text{data} \,\|\, \text{model})$.

THE VERSION THE VAE NEEDS

KL between two bumps: an area



For continuous variables the sum becomes an integral:

$$\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \int q(z)\ \log \frac{q(z)}{p(z)}\, dz$$

Take $q = \mathcal{N}(1, 0.5^2)$, the encoder's cloud, and $p = \mathcal{N}(0, 1)$, the prior.

The shaded area, computed numerically, is **0.818** nats.

Can we get 0.818 without a computer? Yes: for two Gaussians the integral has a formula. Three steps.

GAUSSIAN KL, STEP 1 OF 2

Write out the log of the ratio

$$\log q(z) = -\log \sigma - \tfrac{1}{2}\log 2\pi - \frac{(z-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}$$

log of $\mathcal{N}(z; \mu, \sigma^2)$

$$\log p(z) = -\tfrac{1}{2}\log 2\pi - \frac{z^2}{2}$$

log of $\mathcal{N}(z; 0, 1)$

$$\log \frac{q(z)}{p(z)} = -\log \sigma - \frac{(z-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2} + \frac{z^2}{2}$$

subtract: the $\frac{1}{2}\log 2\pi$ terms cancel

Three terms. Next: average each one over $z \sim q$.

GAUSSIAN KL, STEP 2 OF 2

Average each term over the cloud q

$\mathbb{E}_q\left[(z-\mu)^2\right] = \sigma^2$ (that is the variance)

$\mathbb{E}_q\left[z^2\right] = \mu^2 + \sigma^2$ (mean squared + variance)

$$\mathrm{KL} = -\log\sigma - \frac{\sigma^2}{2\sigma^2} + \frac{\mu^2+\sigma^2}{2} = \frac{1}{2}\left(\mu^2 + \sigma^2 - 1 - \log\sigma^2\right)$$

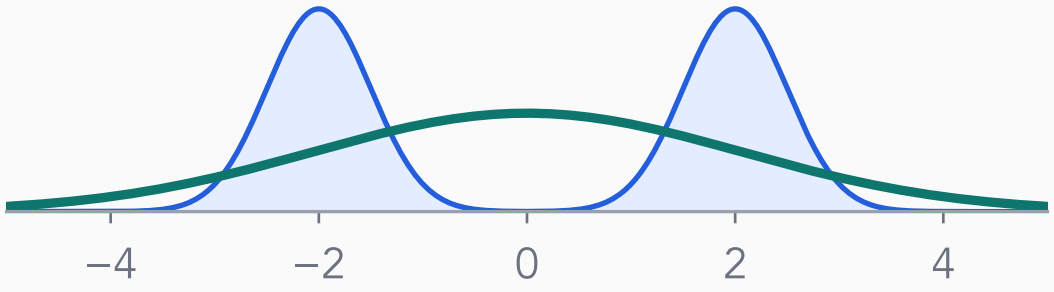
$$\mu = 1,\ \sigma = 0.5: \quad \tfrac{1}{2}\left(1 + 0.25 - 1 + 1.386\right) = 0.818\ \checkmark$$

Moving the mean away costs μ^2; shrinking σ costs $-\log\sigma^2$. For a code with several coordinates, add one such term per coordinate.

BACK TO OUR TWO BUMPS

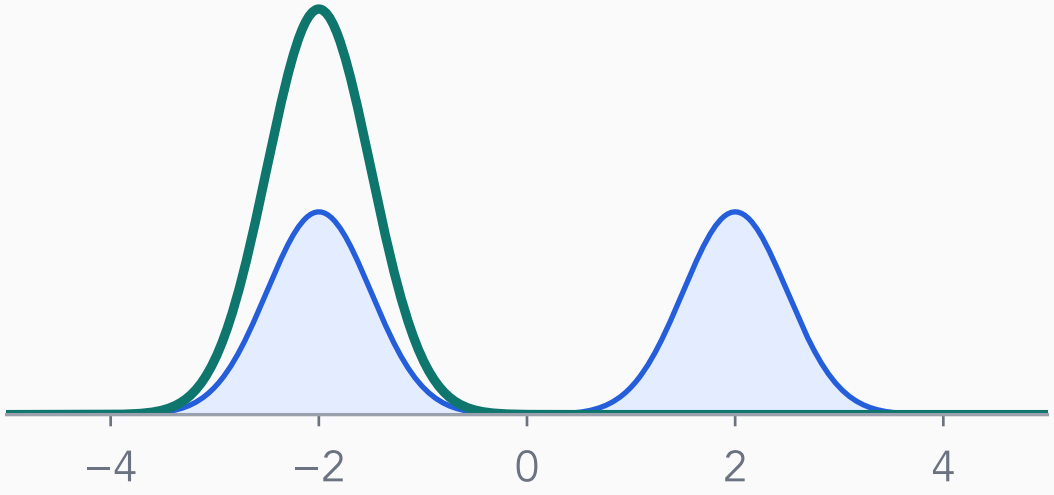
Fit one Gaussian: the KL direction decides what you get

best $q = \mathcal{N}(0.0,\ 2.06^2)$



minimise $\mathrm{KL}(\mathrm{data} \,\|\, q)$: cover everything.
This is the maximum-likelihood fit from before.

best $q = \mathcal{N}(-2.0,\ 0.50^2)$



minimise $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \mathrm{data})$: never put mass where data is absent, so pick one bump.

Mode-covering vs mode-seeking. Keep this picture: it explains blurry VAEs and mode-collapsing GANs.

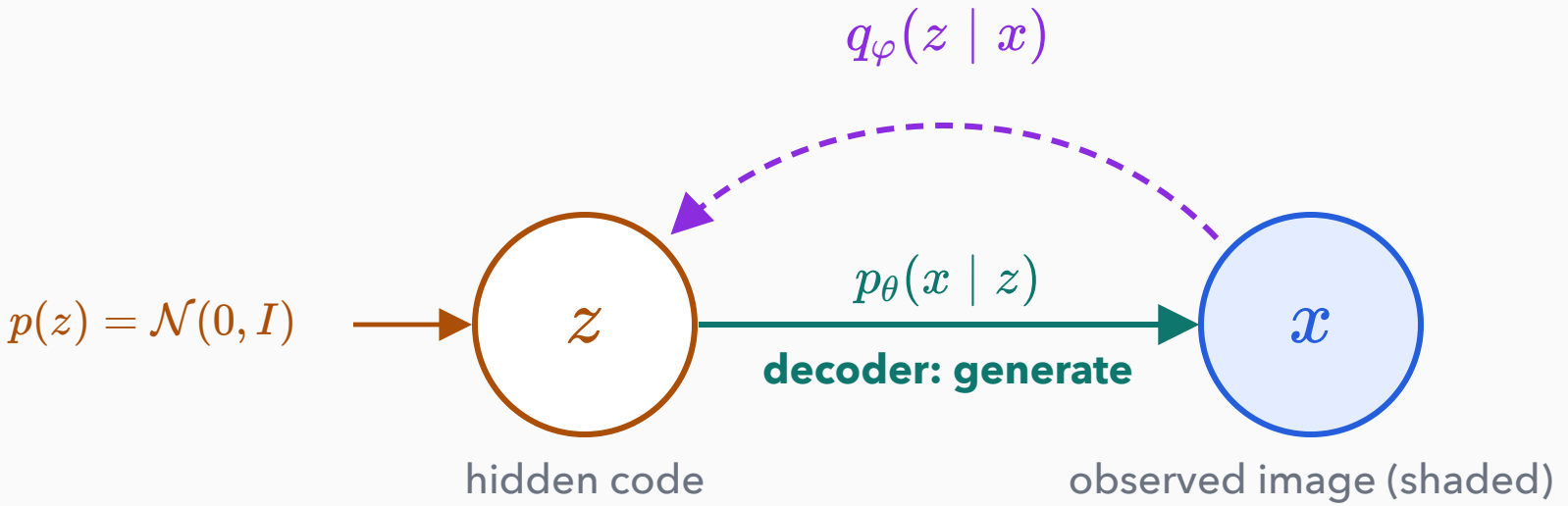
PART 4 · TOOL 2

The ELBO: a loss we can actually compute

Goal: give our 3 high probability, as with the names. Problem: for a latent-variable model that probability is an integral nobody can evaluate. Watch it happen on our 3.

THE MODEL, AS A PICTURE

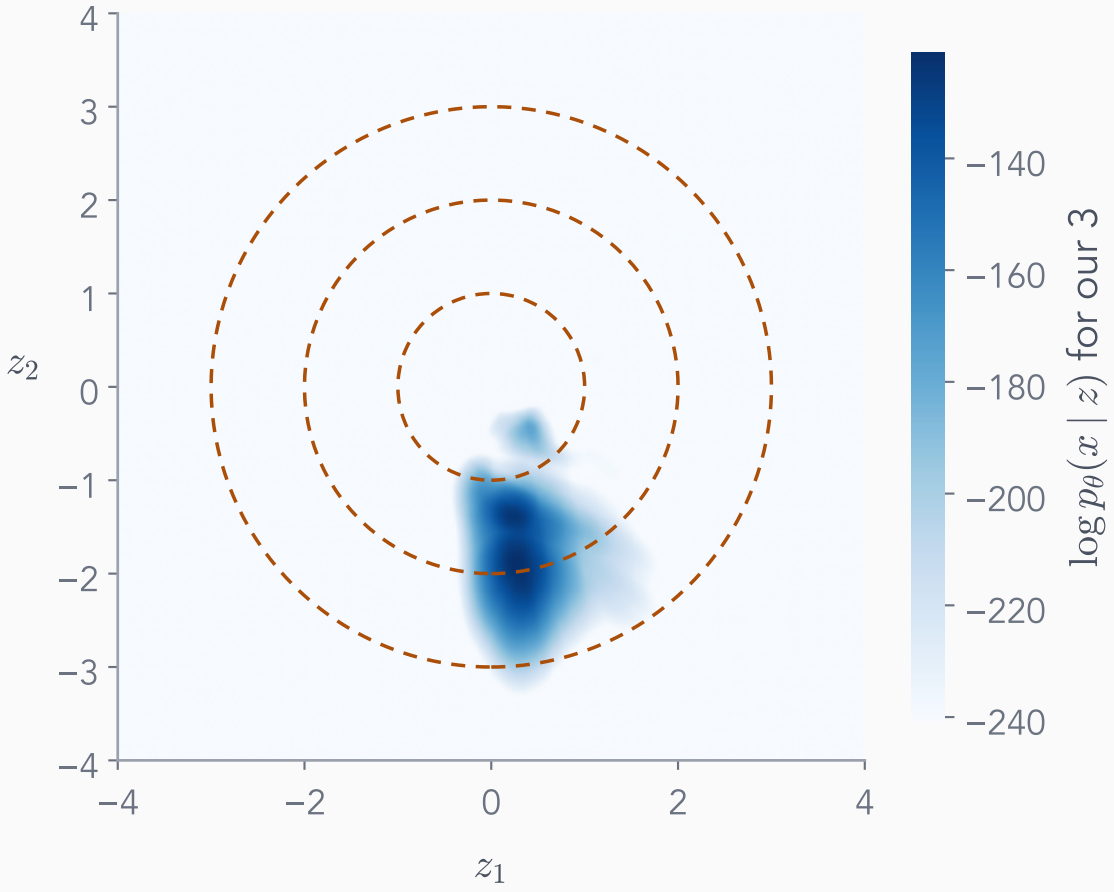
Two arrows: generate down, infer up



$$p_\theta(x, z) = p(z)\, p_\theta(x \mid z)$$

MAXIMUM LIKELIHOOD FOR OUR 3

How probable is our 3 under the model?



With the coin we summed over two values:

$$p(x) = \sum_{z \in \{\mathrm{A},\mathrm{B}\}} p(z)\, p(x \mid z)$$

A code can be any point in the plane, so the sum becomes an integral:

$$p_\theta(x) = \int p(z)\; p_\theta(x \mid z)\, dz$$

2 numbers per code, so we can afford a 901 × 901 grid of decoder calls: $\log p_\theta(x) = -128.7$ nats. With 16 numbers it would be 901^{16} calls.

IDEA: ESTIMATE THE INTEGRAL BY SAMPLING

Random codes almost never hit the right patch

$$p_\theta(x) = \mathbb{E}_{z\sim p(z)}\big[\,p_\theta(x \mid z)\,\big] \approx \frac{1}{S}\sum_{s=1}^{S} p_\theta(x \mid z_s)$$

100,000
random codes $z_s \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$

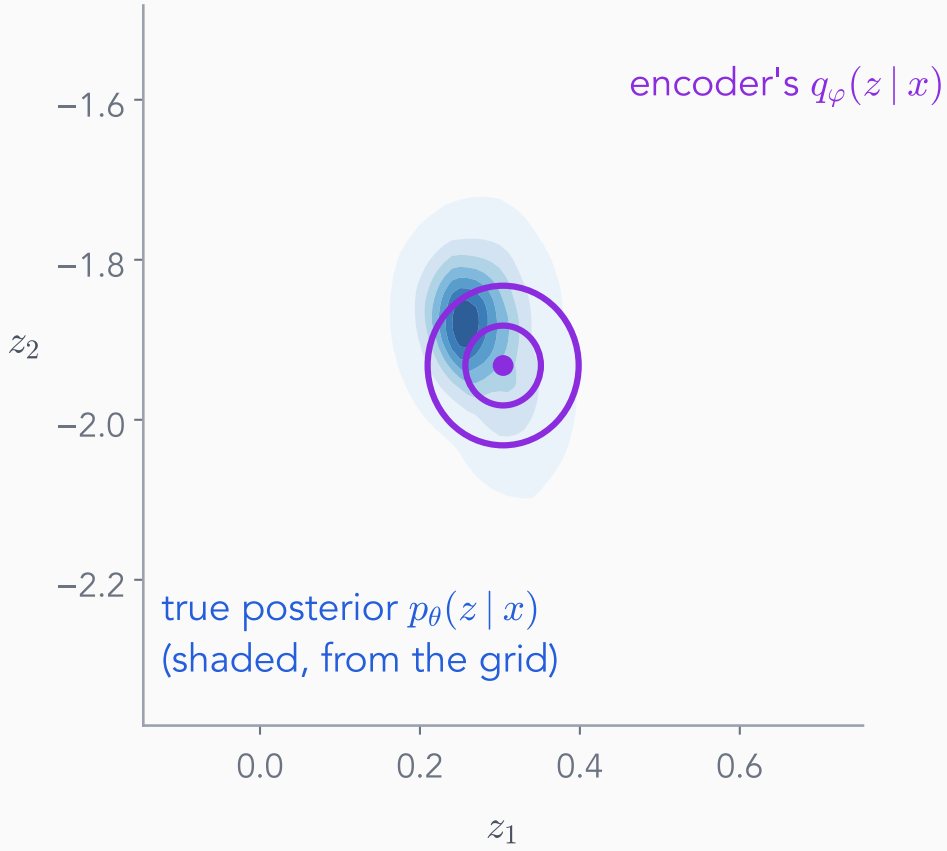
0.07%
land inside our 3's patch

−363.9
typical $\log p(x \mid z)$ of a random code

−121.0
the best code's $\log p(x \mid z)$

> **A typical random code makes our 3 about e^{243} times less probable than the best code. Blind sampling wastes almost every draw.**

Ask the encoder where to look



The patch, normalised, is the true posterior:

$$p_\theta(z \mid x) = \frac{p(z)\, p_\theta(x \mid z)}{p_\theta(x)}$$

It needs $p_\theta(x)$, the impossible integral. So we train a network to guess it:

$$q_\varphi(z \mid x) = \mathcal{N}\big(\mu_\varphi(x),\, \sigma_\varphi(x)^2\big)$$

For our 3: $\mu = (0.3,\ -1.93)$ and $\sigma = (0.047,\ 0.05)$. Close to the truth, not identical.

Start from what we want

$$\log p_\theta(x) = \log \int p_\theta(x, z)\, dz$$

Maximum likelihood wants this number large for our 3, and for every image in the data. The integral over all codes is the part we cannot compute.

We will rewrite this line until it becomes something we can compute and differentiate.

Multiply and divide by the encoder's cloud

$$\log \int p_\theta(x, z)\, dz$$

$$= \log \int q_\varphi(z \mid x)\, \frac{p_\theta(x, z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}\, dz$$

Multiplying and dividing by the same positive number changes nothing. We are free to choose any q; we choose the encoder's Gaussian, which is positive everywhere.

Why bother? Because the next move turns this integral into an average under q, and q knows where the patch is.

Read the integral as an average under q

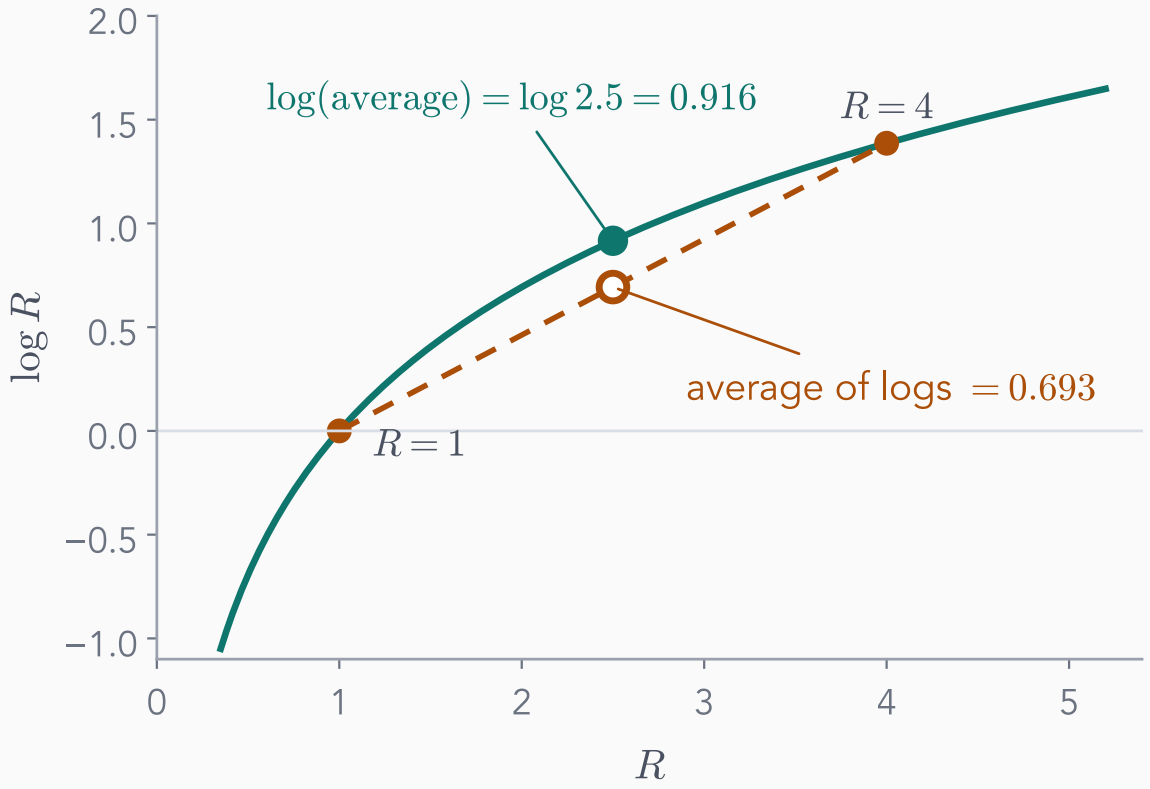
$$\log \int q_\varphi(z \mid x)\, \frac{p_\theta(x, z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}\, dz$$

$$= \log \; \mathbb{E}_{z \sim q_\varphi(z|x)} \left[\frac{p_\theta(x, z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)} \right]$$

From the $\mathbb{E}$ slide: $\int q(z)\, f(z)\, dz = \mathbb{E}_{z \sim q}[f(z)]$. Here $f(z)$ is the ratio $p_\theta(x, z)/q_\varphi(z \mid x)$: one number for each code.

Still exact. We now average over codes drawn from the encoder's cloud, right where the patch is.

Jensen's inequality, in one picture



log curves downwards (it is concave), so every chord lies below the curve.

Two values, $R = 1$ and $R = 4$:

$$\underbrace{\log 2.5}_{\log \text{ of the average}} = 0.916 \geq \underbrace{\tfrac{1}{2}(0 + 1.386)}_{\text{average of the logs}} = 0.693$$

$$\log \mathbb{E}[R] \geq \mathbb{E}[\log R]$$

Swap the log and the average: the only inequality

$$\log p_\theta(x) = \log \mathbb{E}_q\left[\frac{p_\theta(x,z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}\right]$$

$$\log p_\theta(x) \geq \mathbb{E}_q\left[\log \frac{p_\theta(x,z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}\right] =: \mathrm{ELBO}$$

Jensen with $R = p_\theta(x,z)/q_\varphi(z \mid x)$. The right side is the **E**vidence **L**ower **BO**und: it can never exceed $\log p_\theta(x)$.

The log is now inside the average. That is what makes the next three moves possible.

Split the log of a product

$$\text{ELBO} = \mathbb{E}_q\left[\log \frac{p_\theta(x \mid z)\, p(z)}{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}\right]$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_q\Big[\log p_\theta(x \mid z) + \log p(z) - \log q_\varphi(z \mid x)\Big]$$

First write $p_\theta(x, z) = p_\theta(x \mid z)\, p(z)$: decoder times prior. Then $\log \frac{ab}{c} = \log a + \log b - \log c$.

The average of a sum is the sum of the averages

$$\mathbb{E}_q\Big[\log p_\theta(x \mid z) + \log p(z) - \log q_\varphi(z \mid x)\Big]$$

$$= \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p_\theta(x \mid z)\big] + \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(z) - \log q_\varphi(z \mid x)\big]$$

$\mathbb{E}[a + b] = \mathbb{E}[a] + \mathbb{E}[b]$. Group the decoder term on its own, and the two terms that only involve z together.

Recognise the second average: it is a KL

$$\mathbb{E}_q\big[\log p(z) - \log q_\varphi(z \mid x)\big]$$

$$= -\,\mathbb{E}_q\left[\log \frac{q_\varphi(z \mid x)}{p(z)}\right] = \boxed{-\mathrm{KL}\big(q_\varphi(z \mid x)\,\|\,p(z)\big)}$$

Flip the sign to flip the fraction. Then use the definition: $\mathrm{KL}(q\|p) = \mathbb{E}_{z\sim q}\big[\log \frac{q(z)}{p(z)}\big]$, the average extra surprise.

And for Gaussians we already have its formula: $\frac{1}{2}\sum_j(\mu_j^2 + \sigma_j^2 - 1 - \log\sigma_j^2)$.

PUT THE PIECES TOGETHER

The ELBO, in symbols and in words

$$\text{ELBO} = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{z\sim q}\left[\log p_\theta(x \mid z)\right]}_{\text{rebuild } x \text{ from codes in its cloud}} - \underbrace{\text{KL}\left(q_\varphi(z \mid x) \,\|\, p(z)\right)}_{\text{keep the cloud near } \mathcal{N}(0,I)}$$

First term: the autoencoder's reconstruction score, with the code drawn from the cloud.

Second term: the Gaussian KL we just derived.

The two wishes from the autoencoder slide, derived rather than invented. The loss we minimise is $-\text{ELBO}$.

A second route: start from the true posterior

$$\mathrm{KL}\big(q \,\|\, p_\theta(z \mid x)\big) = \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log q_\varphi(z \mid x) - \log p_\theta(z \mid x)\big]$$

definition of KL, now against the **true posterior**

$$= \mathbb{E}_q\big[\log q_\varphi(z \mid x) - \log p_\theta(x, z)\big] + \log p_\theta(x)$$

Bayes: $\log p_\theta(z \mid x) = \log p_\theta(x, z) - \log p_\theta(x)$, and $\log p_\theta(x)$ has no z in it

$$= -\mathrm{ELBO} + \log p_\theta(x)$$

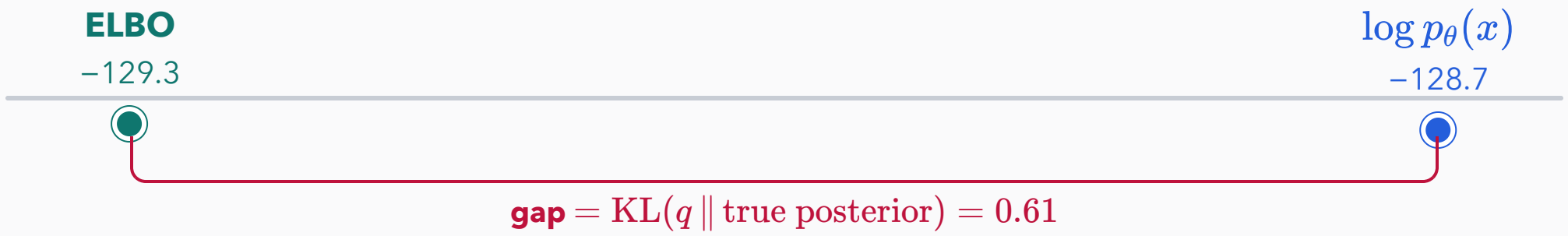
the average is exactly minus the ELBO from move 4

$$\log p_\theta(x) = \mathrm{ELBO} + \mathrm{KL}\big(q_\varphi(z \mid x) \,\|\, p_\theta(z \mid x)\big)$$

The gap is a KL, so it is never negative: a second proof that the ELBO is a lower bound.

THE GAP, MEASURED ON OUR 3

Two different KLs, two different jobs



In the loss: $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{prior}) = 6.97$ nats.
Computable by formula.

In the gap: $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{true posterior}) = 0.61$ nats.
Needs $p_\theta(x)$; we only got it from the grid.

Raising the ELBO raises $\log p_\theta(x)$ or shrinks the gap. Both are what we want.

CHECK THE IDENTITY WITH NUMBERS YOU CAN DO BY HAND

Neat or messy writer? A two-value latent

$z \in \{\text{neat}, \text{messy}\}$, prior $\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$. Observation x: a thick stroke.

$$p(x \mid \text{neat}) = 0.8, \quad p(x \mid \text{messy}) = 0.2$$

evidence $p(x) = 0.5$ · true posterior $(0.8,\ 0.2)$

Our guess $q = (q_0,\ 1 - q_0)$:

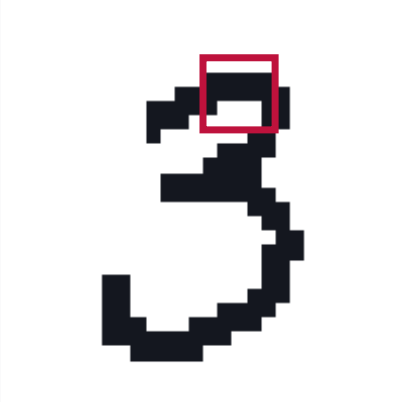
q_0 = `0.60`

quantity	value
$\mathbb{E}_q[\log p(x \mid z)]$	−0.778
$-\,\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{prior})$	−0.020
ELBO	**−0.798**
$+\,\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{posterior})$	0.105
$\log p(x)$	**−0.693**

Move q: the ELBO and the gap change, their sum never does. At q = posterior (0.8) the gap is 0.

THE RECONSTRUCTION TERM, ZOOMED IN

Each pixel is a coin flip with probability π_i



our 3, one 5 × 5 patch

observed x_i				
0	0	0	0	0
1	1	1	1	1
1	1	1	1	1
1	0	0	0	1
0	0	0	0	1

decoder's π_i				
0.38	0.28	0.13	0.05	0.02
0.89	0.82	0.65	0.41	0.18
0.77	0.79	0.76	0.67	0.40
0.41	0.52	0.67	0.66	0.51
0.22	0.35	0.55	0.60	0.48

$-\log p(x_i \mid z)$				
0.48	0.33	0.14	0.05	0.02
0.11	0.19	0.43	0.89	1.71
0.26	0.24	0.28	0.40	0.91
0.89	0.74	1.12	1.09	0.67
0.25	0.44	0.79	0.93	0.74

this 5 × 5 patch: 14.1 nats

$$-\log p_\theta(x \mid z) = -\sum_{i=1}^{784} \Big[x_i \log \pi_i + (1 - x_i) \log(1 - \pi_i) \Big] = 122.3 \text{ nats}$$

> **Binary cross-entropy is not a design choice: it is the Bernoulli log-likelihood. Gaussian pixels would give squared error.**

FROM THEORY TO THE TRAINING LOSS

The VAE loss for our 3

$$\mathcal{L}(x) = -\text{ELBO} \approx \underbrace{-\log p_\theta(x \mid z)}_{\text{BCE over 784 pixels}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{2}\left(\mu_j^2 + \sigma_j^2 - 1 - \log \sigma_j^2\right)}_{\text{KL over 2 coordinates}}, \qquad z \sim q_\varphi(z \mid x)$$

122.3
reconstruction, one draw of z

+ 6.97
KL, exact formula

= 129.2
loss for our 3

> **One problem left: z is a random draw, and we need gradients through it.**

SESSION 2 · WHERE WE STOPPED

Last time: a loss for a latent-variable model

$$\mathcal{L}(x) = \underbrace{-\log p_\theta(x \mid z)}_{\text{reconstruction}} + \underbrace{\mathrm{KL}\big(q_\varphi(z \mid x) \,\|\, \mathcal{N}(0, I)\big)}_{\text{cloud vs. prior}}, \qquad z \sim q_\varphi(z \mid x)$$

122.3
reconstruction for our 3

+ 6.97
KL for our 3

= 129.2
its loss, one draw of z

Why it is principled: $-\mathcal{L}$ is a lower bound on $\log p_\theta(x)$, short by $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{true posterior})$.

Still missing: how to train it. The z in the middle is a random draw.

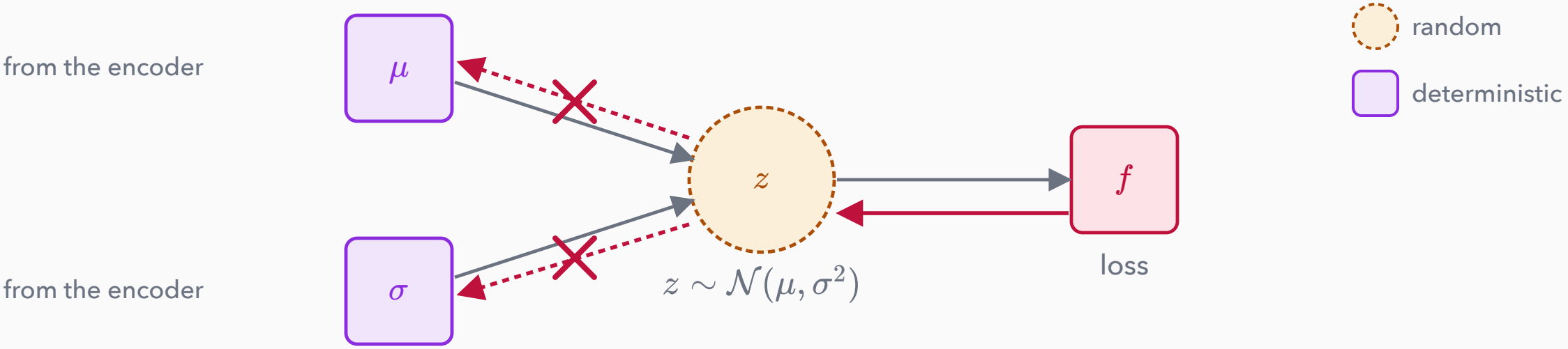
PART 5 · TOOL 3

Backpropagating through a random draw

The loss uses a z sampled from the encoder's cloud. To train the encoder, gradients must get from the loss back to μ and σ.

THE PROBLEM

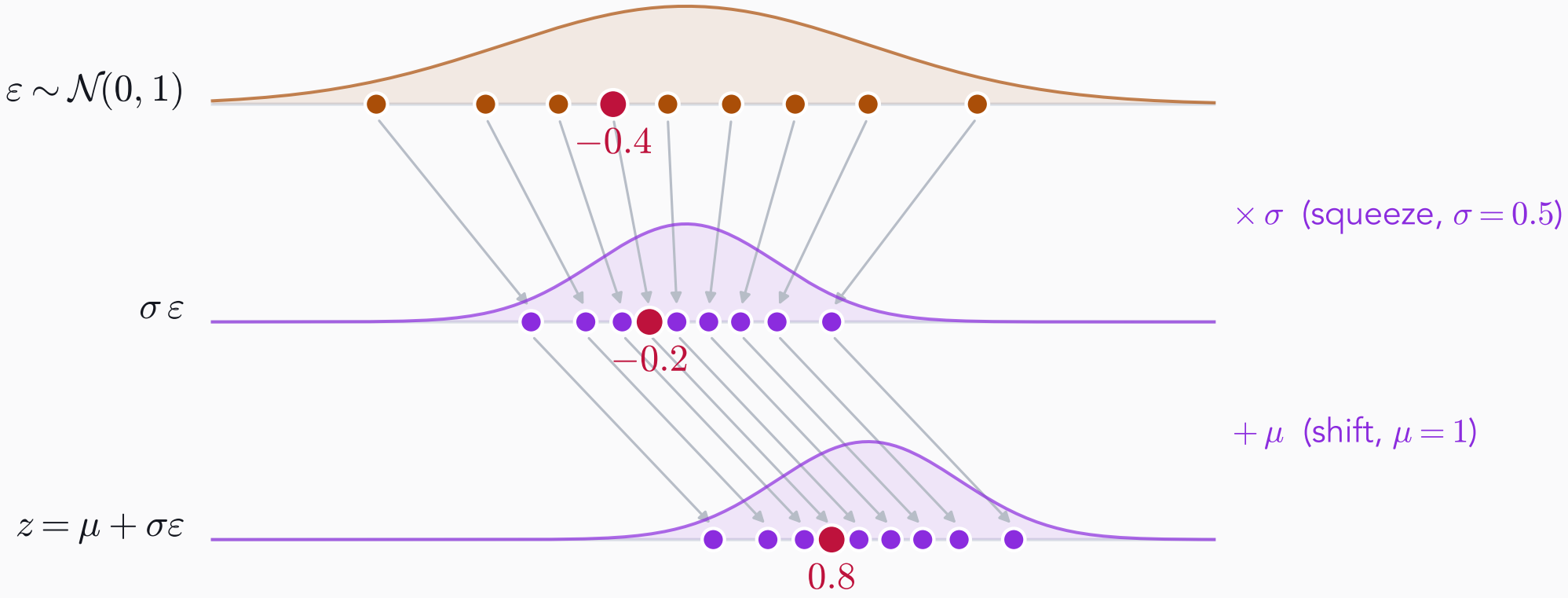
A sampling step sits in the middle of the graph



the loss knows how z should move, but z is a fresh random draw: how does it change when μ or σ changes a little?

THE TRICK

Draw standard noise first, then stretch and shift it

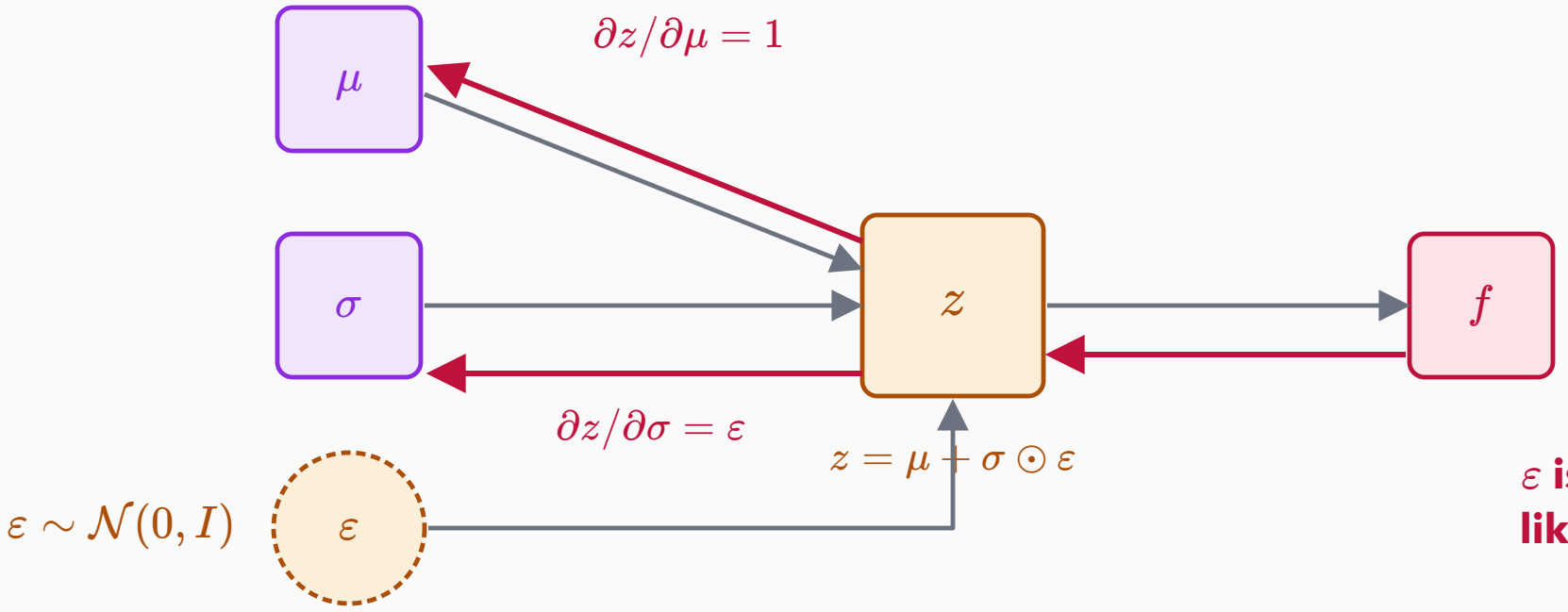


$$z = \mu + \sigma\,\varepsilon, \quad \varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0,1) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad z \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$$

> **Same distribution as before. But the randomness now enters as an input, ε, that does not depend on any weights.**

THE FIX

Now the path from the loss to μ and σ is ordinary arithmetic



ε is just an input, like a pixel value

Take $f(z) = z^2$ as the loss

$$z = \mu + \sigma\varepsilon \qquad \Rightarrow \qquad \frac{\partial z}{\partial \mu} = 1, \qquad \frac{\partial z}{\partial \sigma} = \varepsilon, \qquad \frac{\partial f}{\partial z} = 2z$$

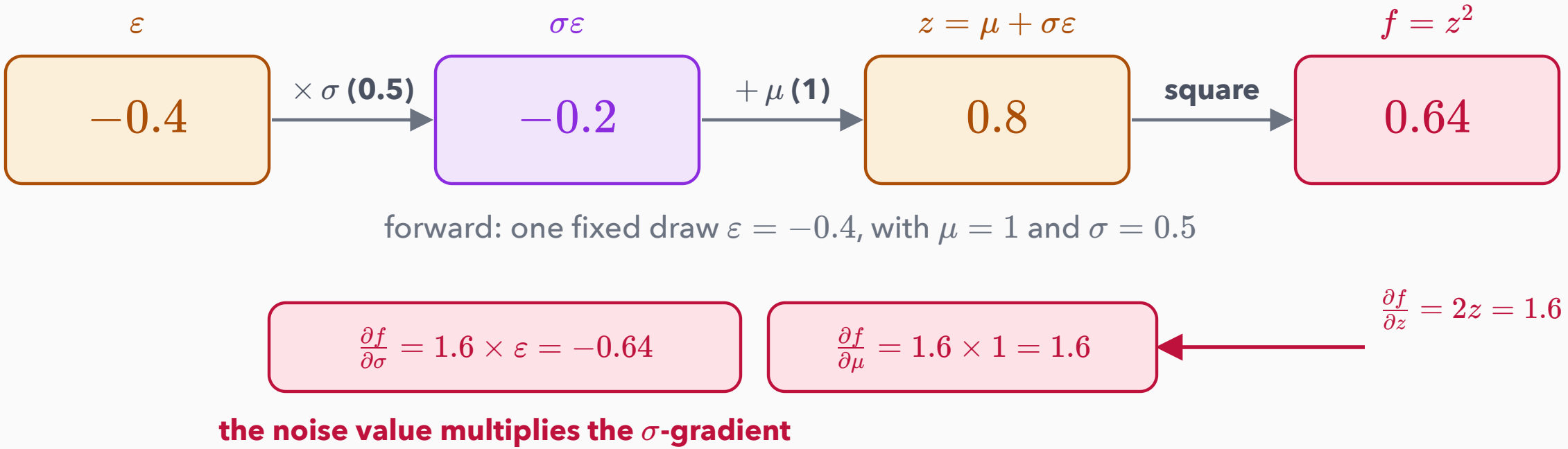
$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial \mu} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial z} \cdot \frac{\partial z}{\partial \mu} = 2z \cdot 1$$

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial \sigma} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial z} \cdot \frac{\partial z}{\partial \sigma} = 2z \cdot \varepsilon$$

The noise value ε appears in the σ-gradient: a draw far from the centre pushes σ harder.

NOW PLUG IN NUMBERS

$$\mu = 1,\ \sigma = 0.5,\ \varepsilon = -0.4$$



the noise value multiplies the σ-gradient

ONE MORE LINK IN THE CHAIN

The network outputs $v = \log \sigma^2$, not σ

$$\sigma = e^{v/2}$$

v can be any real number; σ is always positive

$$\frac{\partial \sigma}{\partial v} = \tfrac{1}{2} e^{v/2} = \frac{\sigma}{2} = 0.25$$

derivative of $e^{v/2}$

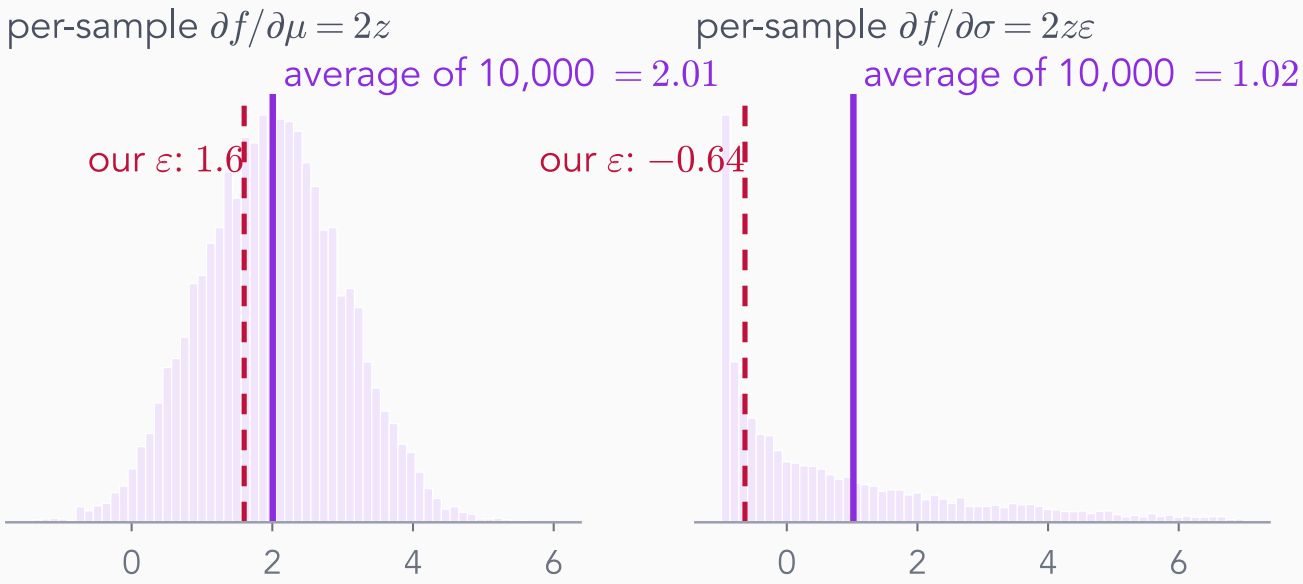
$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial v} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial \sigma} \cdot \frac{\partial \sigma}{\partial v} = -0.64 \times 0.25 = -0.16$$

one more chain-rule factor

Autograd does exactly this. The point of doing it by hand once: no step is magic.

One draw is noisy; the average is exactly right

$$\mathbb{E}_\varepsilon\big[f\big] = \mathbb{E}\big[(\mu+\sigma\varepsilon)^2\big] = \mu^2+\sigma^2 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \frac{\partial}{\partial\mu}\mathbb{E}[f] = 2\mu = 2, \qquad \frac{\partial}{\partial\sigma}\mathbb{E}[f] = 2\sigma = 1$$



Our single ε gave 1.6 and -0.64. Averaged over 10000 draws: 2.01 and 1.02. SGD only needs the right answer on average.

IN PYTORCH

Three lines

```
# encoder outputs, shape [B, 2] each
mu, logvar = encoder(x)
std = torch.exp(0.5 * logvar)      # sigma = exp(v / 2)
eps = torch.randn_like(std)        # standard normal, no grad
z   = mu + std * eps               # differentiable in mu, std
```

Why output $\log \sigma^2$? It can be any real number; σ must be positive.

`Normal(mu, std).rsample()` does the same thing; `.sample()` drops the gradient.

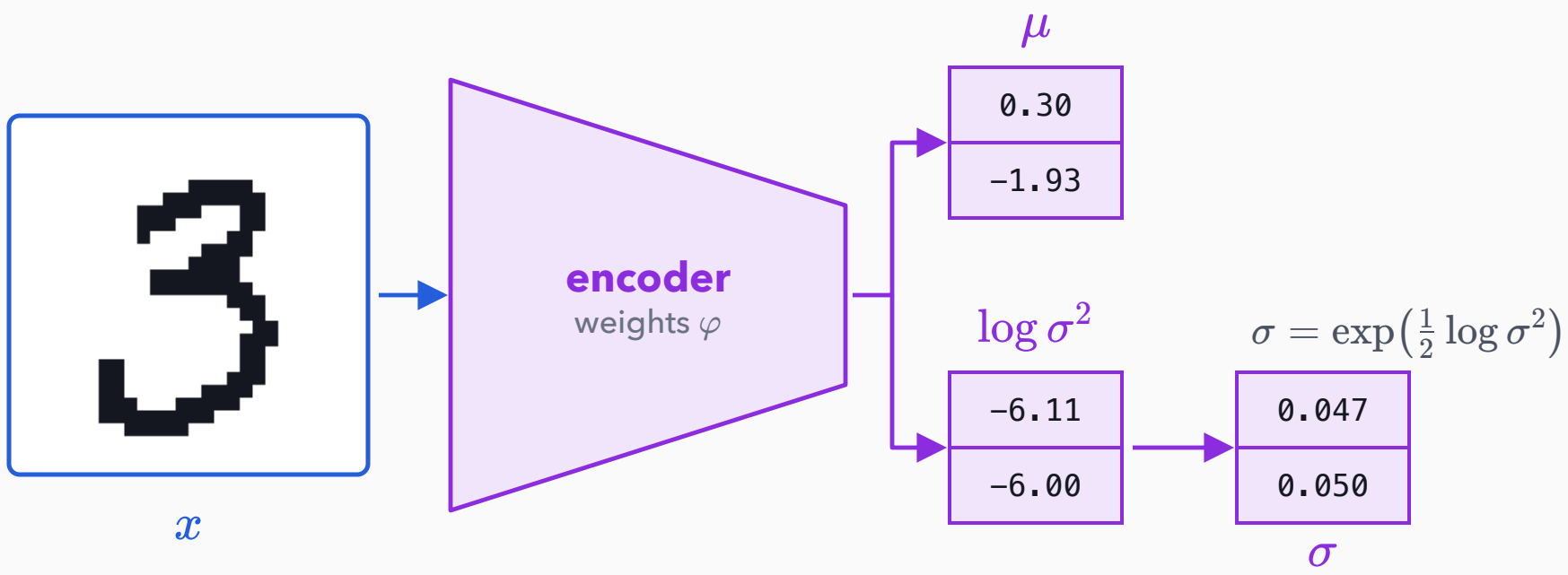
For our 3: $\mu = (0.3,\ -1.93)$, $\varepsilon = (0.62,\ -1.15)$ gives $z = (0.33,\ -1.99)$.

PART 6

The variational autoencoder, end to end

Every piece is now in place. Follow our 3 through the trained network, then see what the model can generate.

Encode: the image becomes a cloud



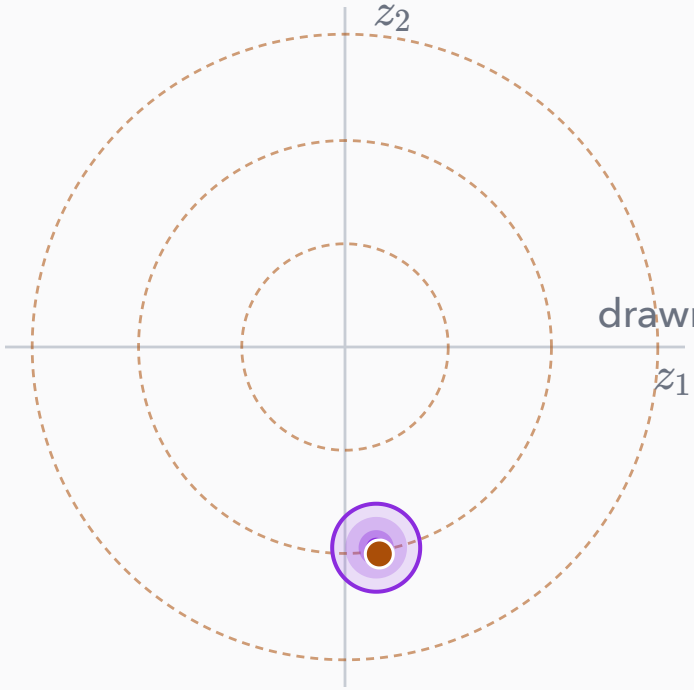
a cloud centred at μ with width σ:

$$q_\varphi(z \mid x) = \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$$

$\sigma \approx 0.05$ against the prior's $\sigma = 1$: the encoder is very sure where our 3 belongs.

Sample: one code from inside the cloud

the cloud in code space



ε

$\varepsilon = (0.62,\ -1.15)$

drawn from a standard normal once

$$z_1 = \mu_1 + \sigma_1 \varepsilon_1$$
$$= 0.30 + 0.047 \times 0.62 = 0.33$$

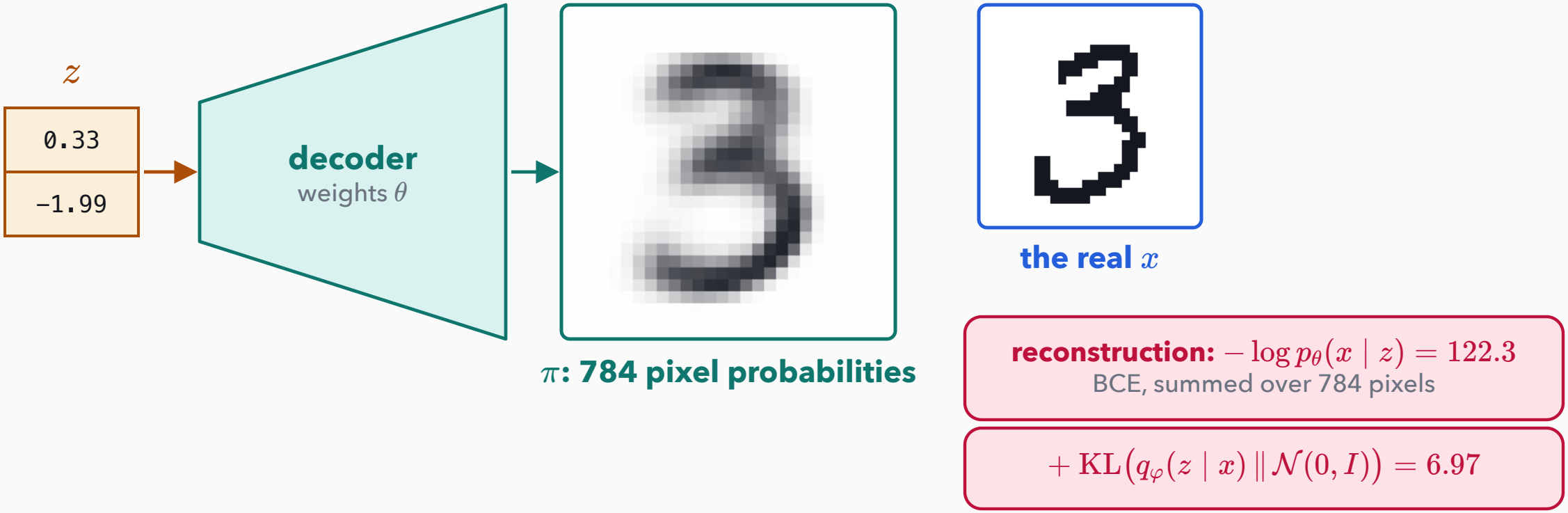
$$z_2 = \mu_2 + \sigma_2 \varepsilon_2$$
$$= -1.93 + 0.050 \times (-1.15) = -1.99$$

$z =$

0.33	-1.99

one code from inside the cloud

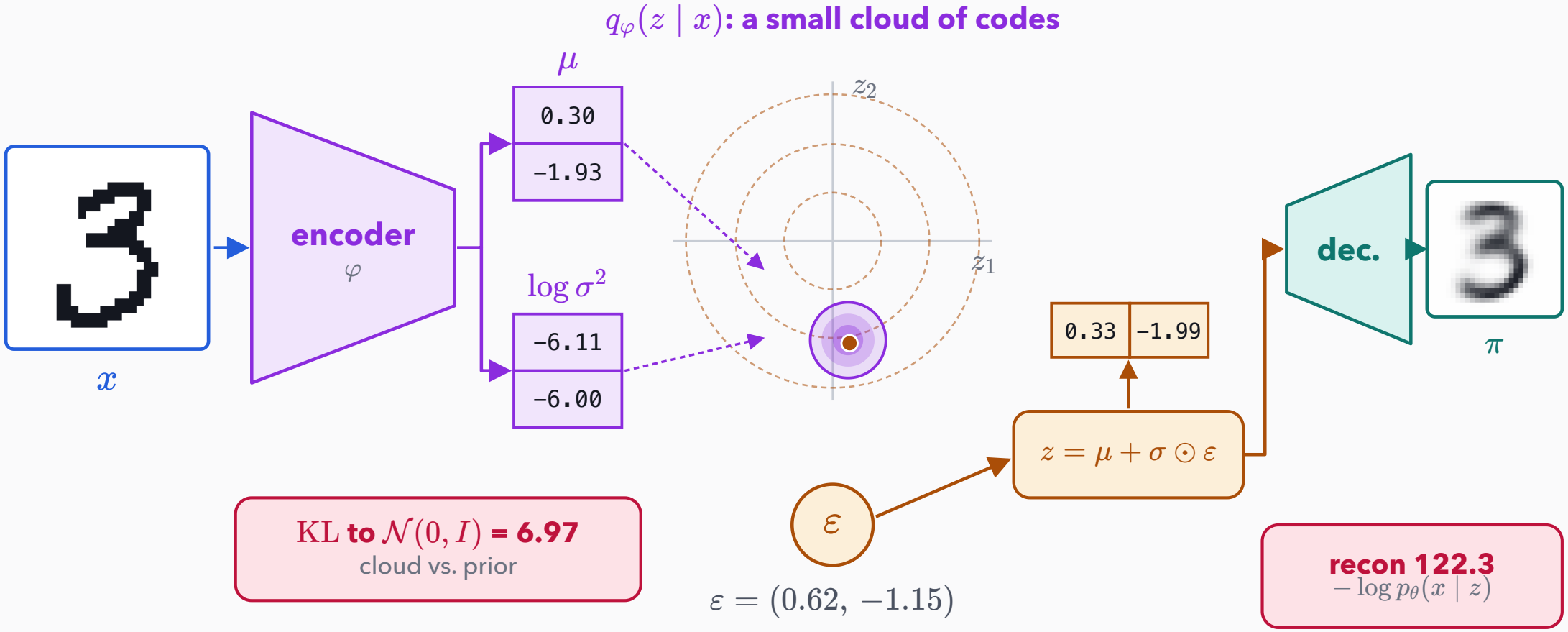
Decode, then score against the real 3



Loss for our 3: $122.3 + 6.97 = 129.2$ nats. Backpropagate it into both θ and φ.

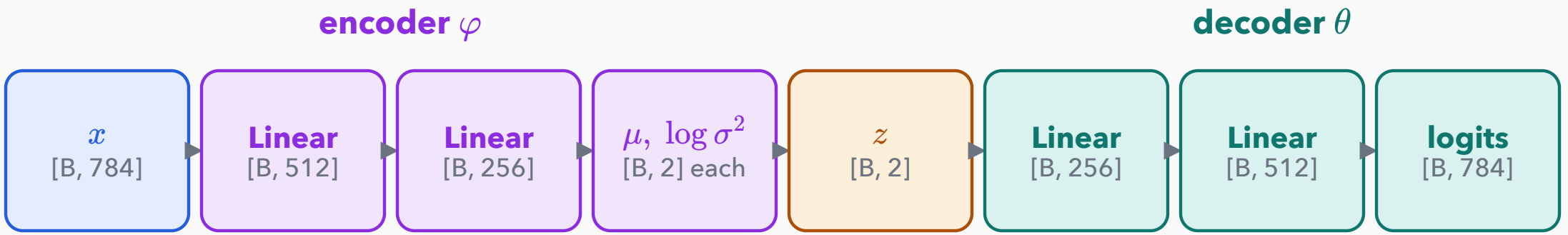
ALL THREE STEPS ON ONE PAGE

The whole VAE, for our 3



THE SAME NETWORK AS TENSORS

Shapes, layer by layer



B = batch size. Only the 2 in the middle is the code; ε has the same shape as μ.

Loss per image: BCE summed over 784 pixels + KL summed over 2 coordinates.
Then average over the B images in the batch.

THE KL TERM FOR OUR 3

A tight cloud is expensive

$$\mathrm{KL} = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_j \left(\mu_j^2 + \sigma_j^2 - 1 - \log \sigma_j^2\right)$$

coordinate	μ_j	σ_j	μ_j^2	$\sigma_j^2 - 1$	$-\log \sigma_j^2$	$\frac{1}{2}(\text{sum})$
z_1	0.3	0.047	0.09	-1.00	6.11	**2.6**
z_2	−1.93	0.05	3.72	-1.00	6.00	**4.37**
total						**6.97 nats**

$$-\log \sigma_1^2 = -\log(0.047^2) = -\log 0.0022 = 6.11$$

> **Most of the cost is $-\log \sigma^2$: the price of being precise. Reconstruction wants precision; the KL resists.**

ONE TRAINING STEP

The whole algorithm fits on a slide

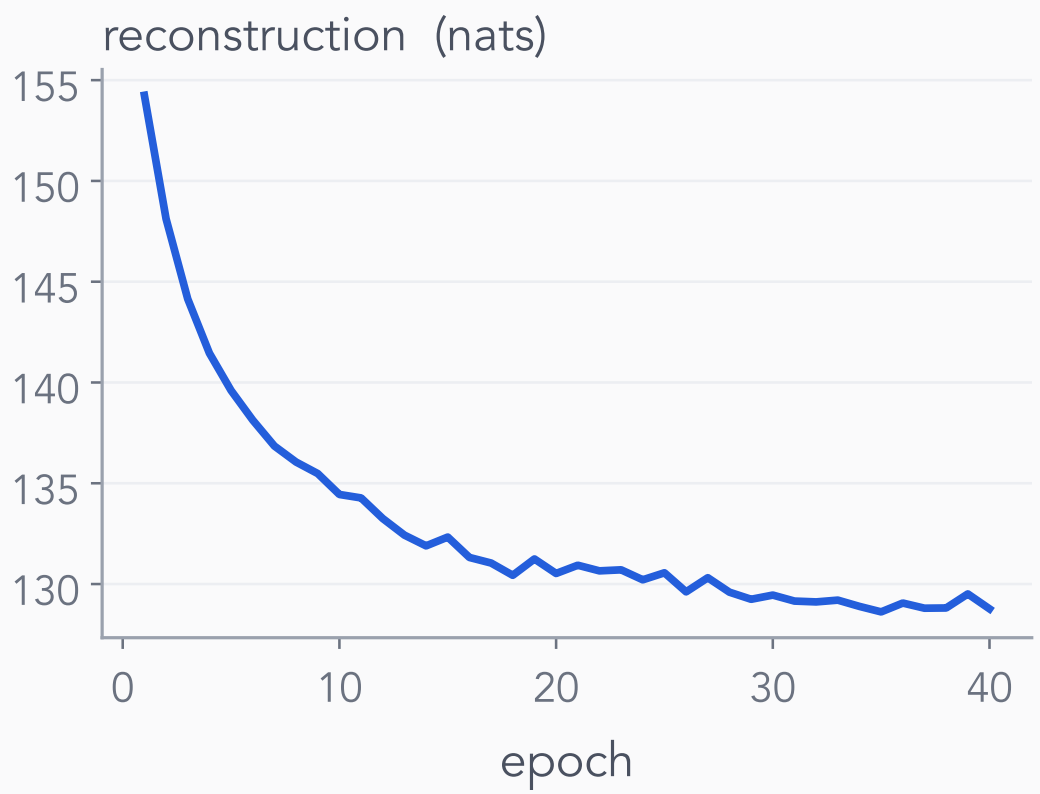
```
mu, logvar = model.encoder(x)              # [B,2], [B,2]
z = mu + torch.exp(0.5*logvar) * torch.randn_like(mu)
logits = model.decoder(z)                  # [B,784]
recon = F.binary_cross_entropy_with_logits(
          logits, x.flatten(1), reduction="none").sum(1)
kl = 0.5 * (mu**2 + logvar.exp() - 1 - logvar).sum(1)
loss = (recon + kl).mean()                 # per image, then batch
opt.zero_grad(); loss.backward(); opt.step()
```

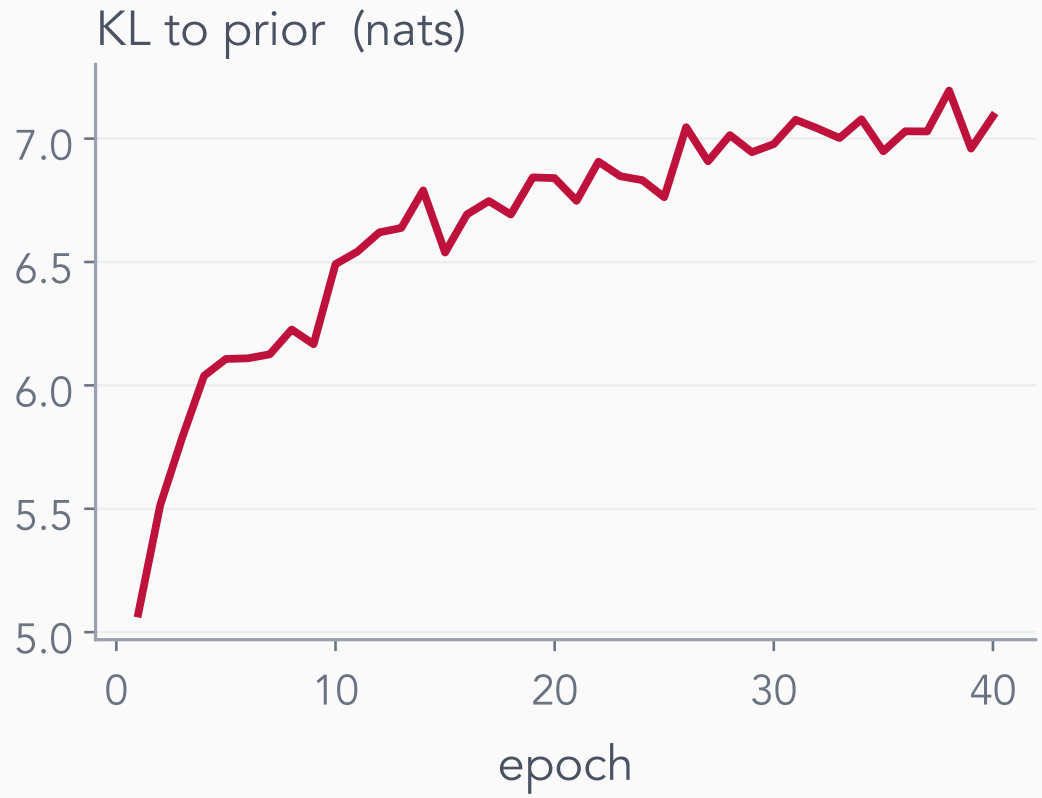
Add per image, average over the batch, step both encoder and decoder.

Averaging BCE over pixels instead of summing silently makes the KL 784× stronger.

TRAINING RUN, TEST SET

Reconstruction falls, KL rises, then both settle

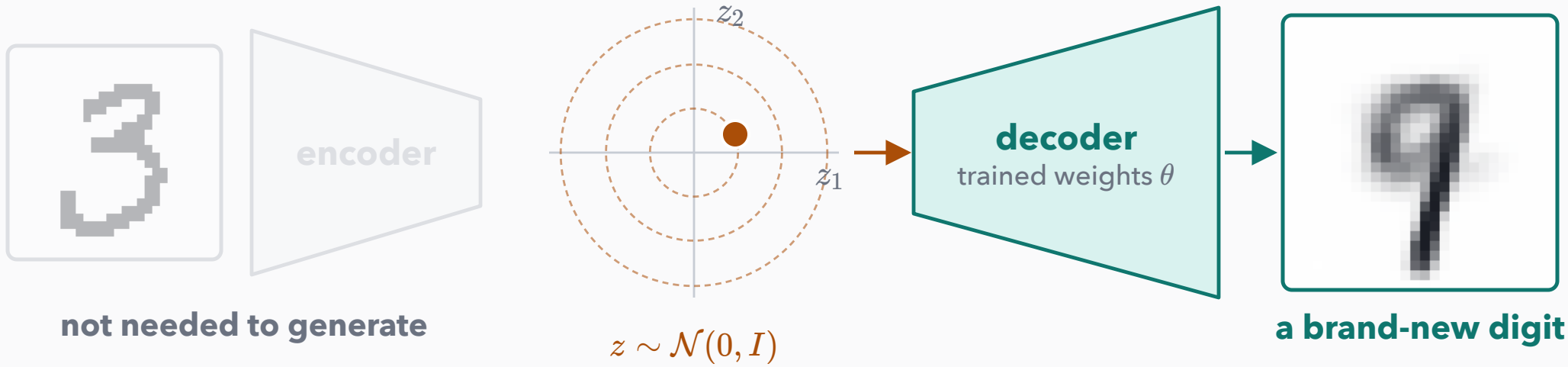




After 40 epochs: reconstruction 128.8 + KL 7.1 = 135.9 nats per test image.

THE PAYOFF

Generate: random code → decoder. No encoder.



This is the whole generator. The encoder was scaffolding for training.

48 RANDOM CODES EACH

Samples from two VAEs



2-number code · reconstruction 128.8

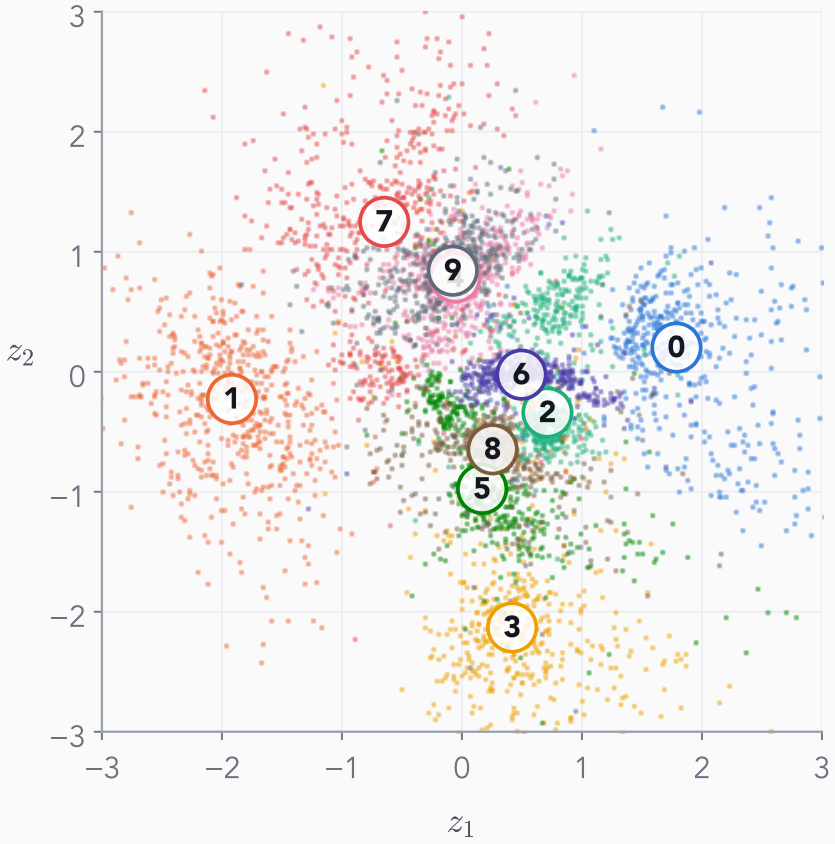


16-number code · reconstruction 57.8

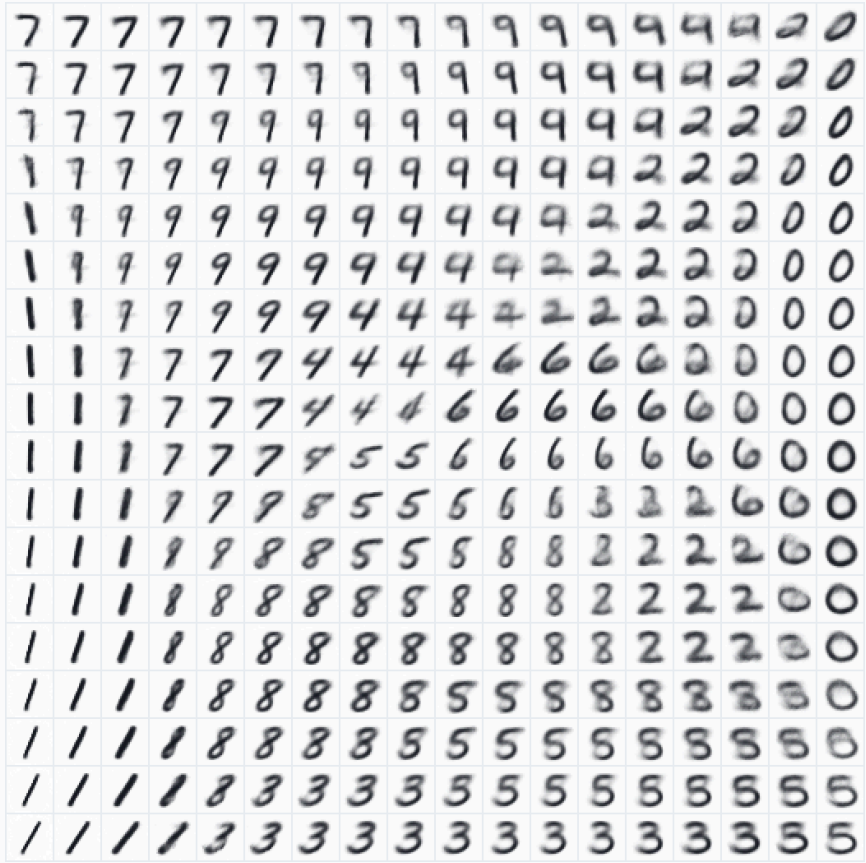
More code dimensions: sharper and more varied, but some samples are odd. Neither is perfect.

BECAUSE THE CODE IS 2-D, WE CAN DRAW THE WHOLE MAP

Every point in the code space is a digit



where test digits land



decoded on an 18 × 18 grid, spaced by quantiles of $\mathcal{N}(0, 1)$

Neighbouring codes give similar digits, and every region decodes to something plausible.

THE COVER, EXPLAINED

Walk in a straight line from our 3 to a 7



encode both, take 12 evenly spaced points between their μ's, decode each (16-number VAE)

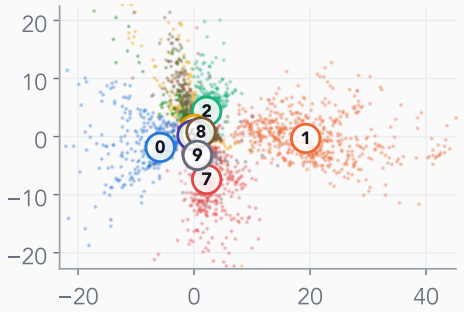


the same walk in the 2-number VAE: the line passes through the 5, 8, 4 and 9 regions on the map

THE TUG OF WAR, MADE VISIBLE

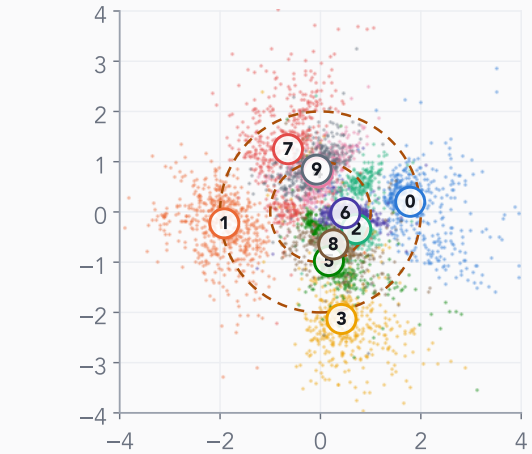
No KL, normal KL, too much KL

autoencoder (no KL)



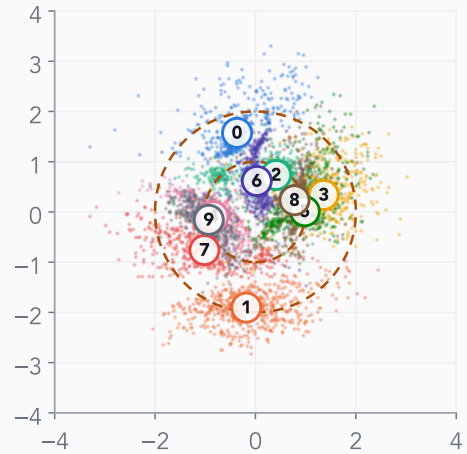
recon 128.1 · KL 0

VAE, loss = recon + KL



recon 128.8 · KL 7.1

recon + 8 × KL



recon 140.4 · KL 3.9

> **Rows: code space · reconstructions · random samples. Too little KL: samples fail. Too much: everything blurs together.**

AN HONEST LOOK

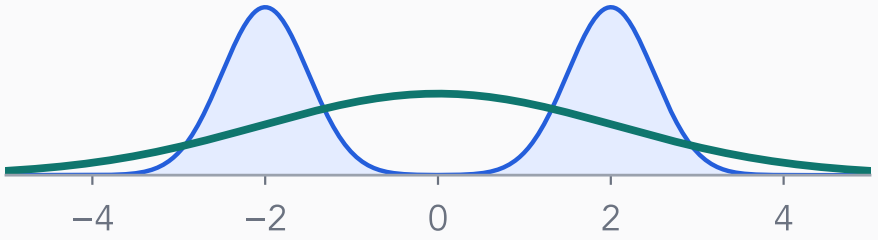
Why are VAE samples blurry?

1. It fits $\mathrm{KL}(\text{data} \,\|\, \text{model})$. Like the wide Gaussian on our bumps, it must cover every training digit, so when unsure it spreads probability.

2. Pixels are independent given z. The decoder outputs one probability per pixel. If a stroke could be here or one pixel over, the best π is grey in both places.

3. We show π, the mean, not a sample. A sample would be speckled instead of grey.

best $q = \mathcal{N}(0.0,\ 2.06^2)$





π (the mean)



a sample

Not a law of nature: bigger codes, better decoders and better likelihoods all sharpen VAEs.

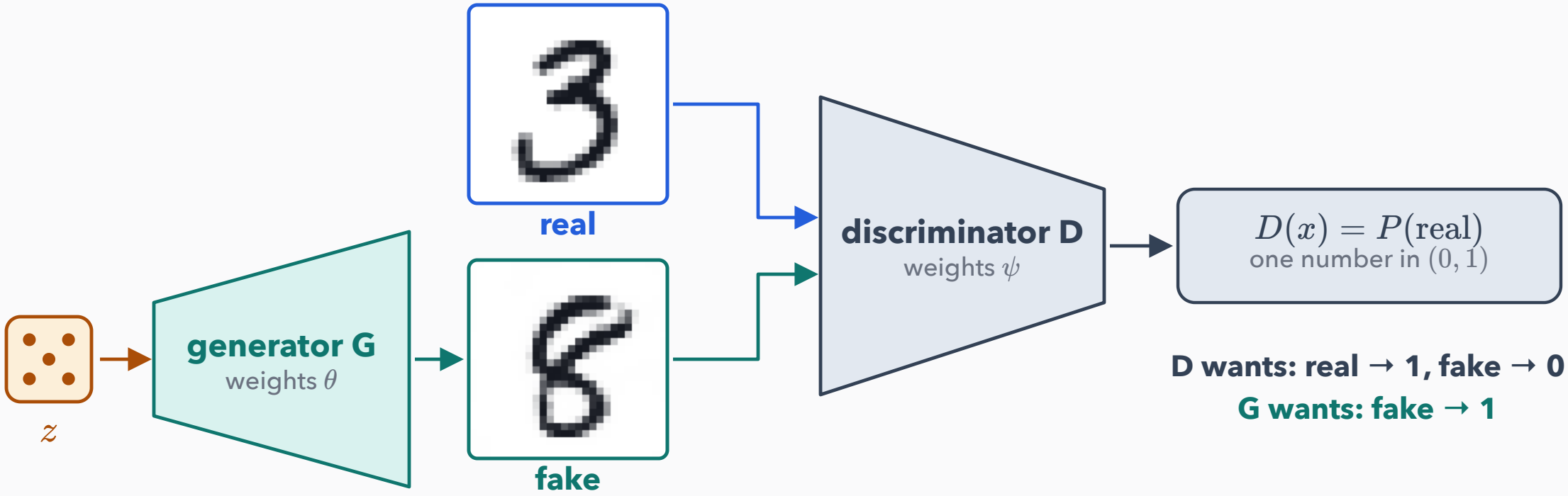
PART 7

GANs: learn the judge instead of the likelihood

Drop the encoder and the ELBO. Train a second network to tell real from fake, and train the generator to fool it.

REMEMBER THE VOTE? YOU WERE THE DISCRIMINATOR.

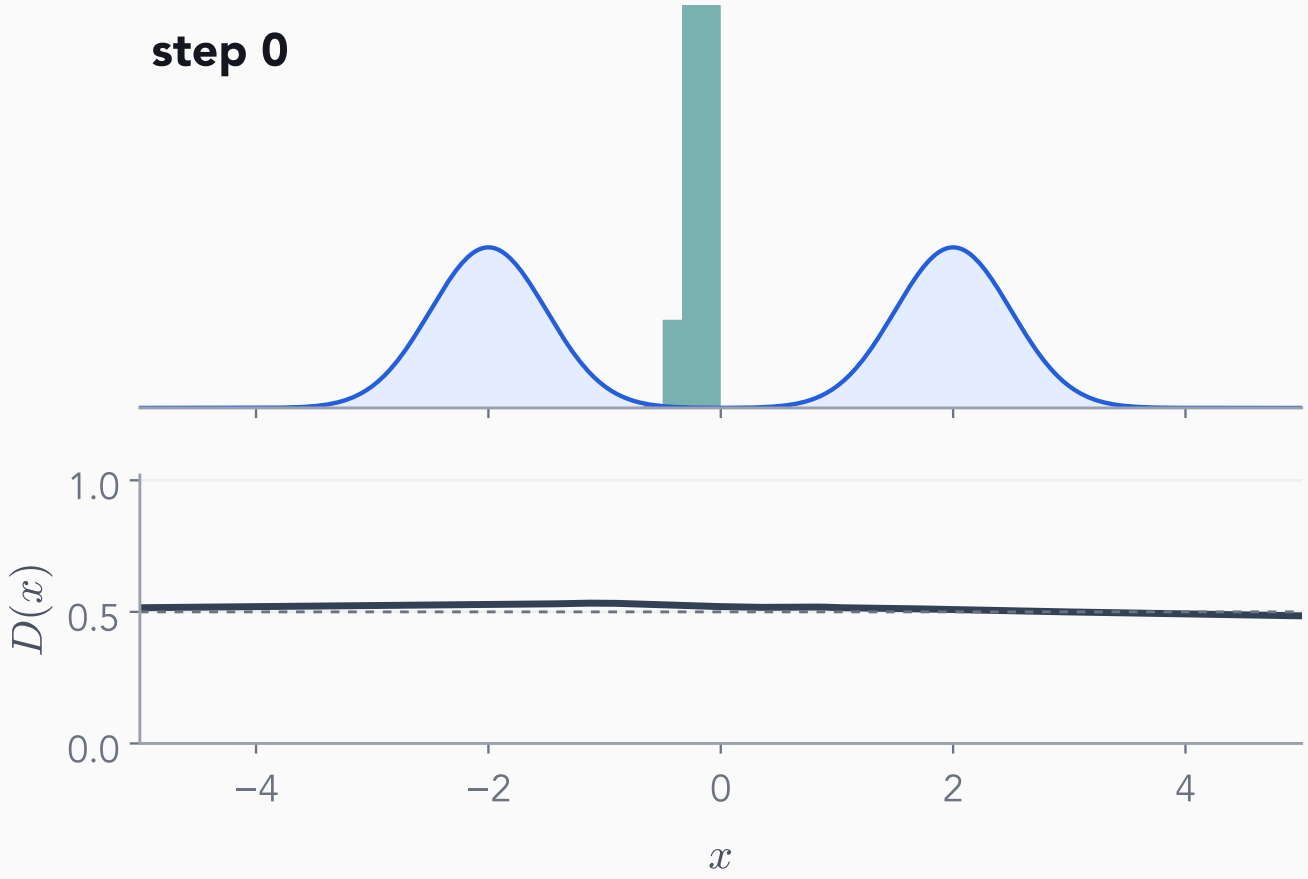
Two networks, one game



No likelihood, no encoder. The training signal for G comes entirely from D.

BACK TO OUR 1-D BUMPS

A GAN on the toy data, at step 0



- blue: the real data
- teal: G's samples for 2,000 fixed z
- slate: D(x), the probability that x is real

G: 1 number in, 1 number out. D: 1 number in, 1 logit out. Both small MLPs.

Untrained, G squeezes everything into one spike near 0 and D says 0.5 everywhere.

STEP 1 OF EACH ITERATION

The discriminator is an ordinary binary classifier

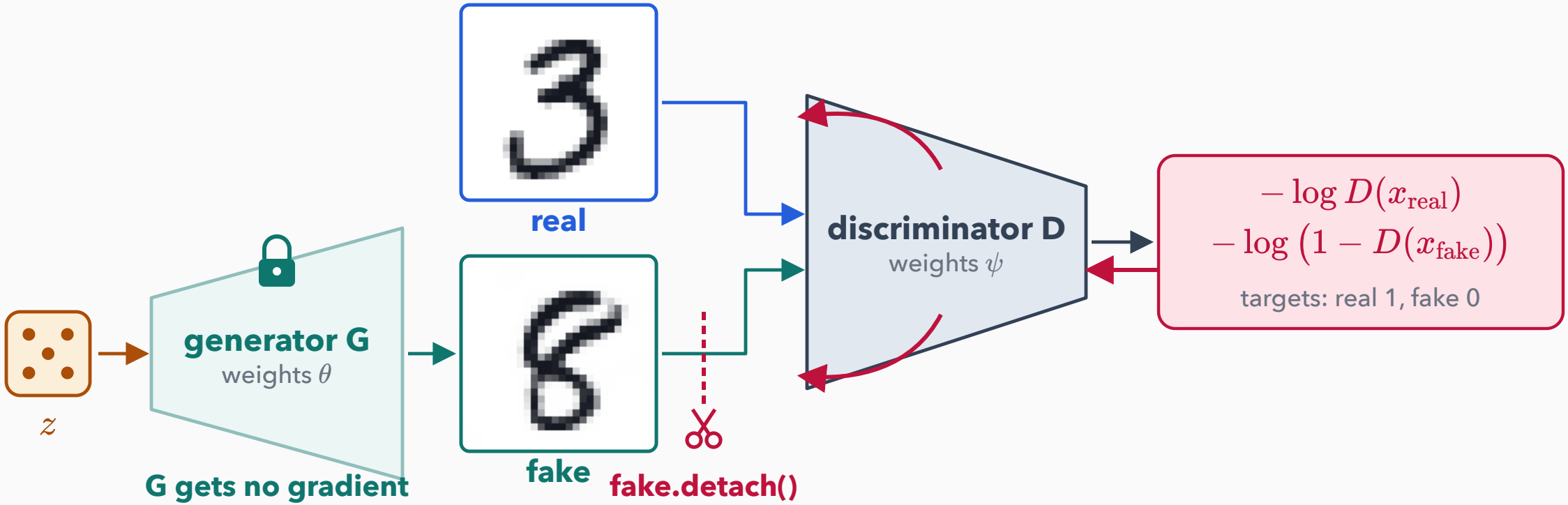
$$\mathcal{L}_D = -\log D(x_{\text{real}}) \; - \; \log\big(1 - D(G(z))\big)$$

input	label	D says	loss
a real digit	1	0.8	$-\log 0.8 = 0.223$
a fake digit	0	0.3	$-\log(1 - 0.3) = 0.357$
$\mathcal{L}_D$			**0.580**

> **Real → 1, fake → 0, binary cross-entropy. Nothing new, except that the "fake" examples keep changing.**

UPDATE D, HOLD G FIXED

D step: cut the wire to G with detach()




```
fake = G(torch.randn(B, zdim))
loss_D = bce(D(real), ones) + bce(D(fake.detach()), zeros)
opt_D.zero_grad(); loss_D.backward(); opt_D.step()
```

WHERE G'S GRADIENT COMES FROM

The chain rule runs through D

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}_G}{\partial \theta} = \underbrace{\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}_G}{\partial D}}_{= -1/D} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial D}{\partial x}}_{\text{slope of } D \text{ at the fake}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial x}{\partial \theta}}_{\text{how } \theta \text{ moves the fake}}, \qquad x = G_\theta(z)$$

$-1/D$ is always negative: raising D always lowers $\mathcal{L}_G$.

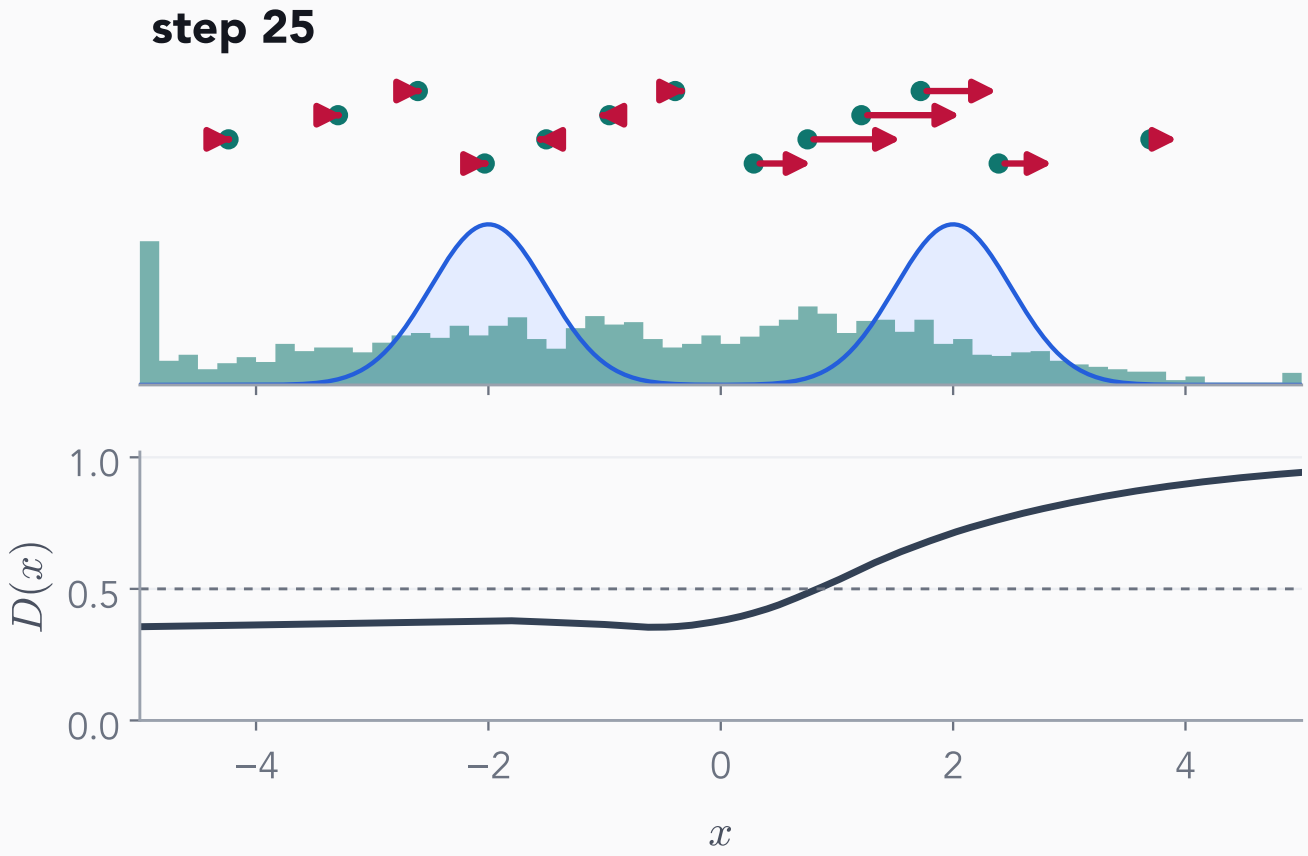
$\partial D/\partial x$: which way is "more real" at this fake. Needs D's weights, but does not change them.

$\partial x/\partial \theta$: ordinary backprop through G.

So the fake moves uphill on D, and G's weights change to make that move. Next: watch it on the 1-D data.

STEP 2: WHAT WOULD FOOL D?

G step: push every fake uphill on D(x)



$$\mathcal{L}_G = -\log D(G(z))$$

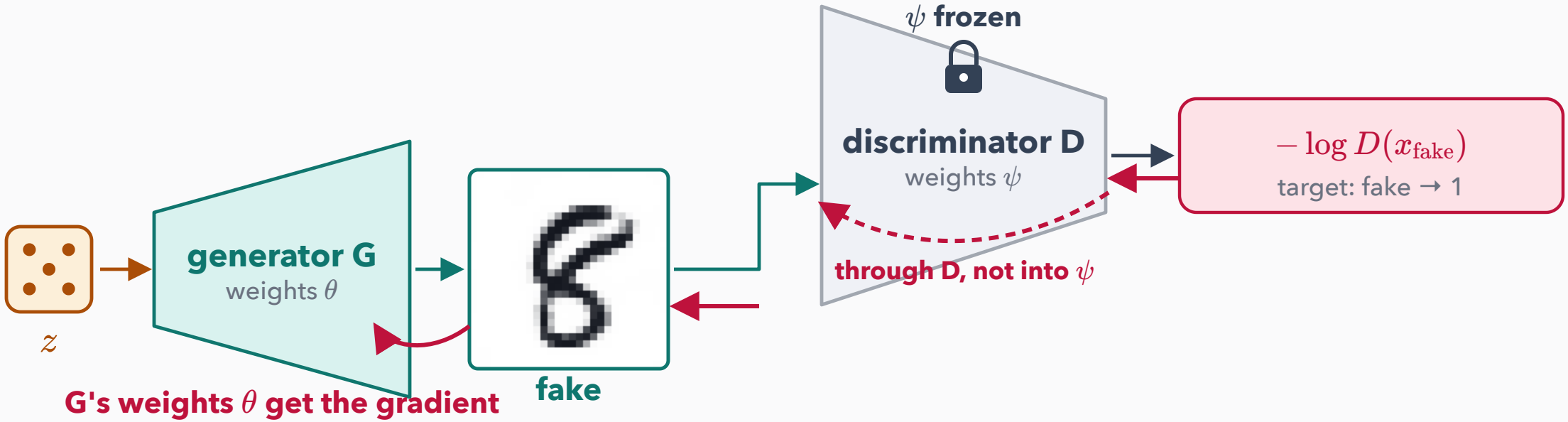
Same BCE, but now the fakes are labelled 1: "make D call these real".

The gradient tells each fake which way D(x) increases. Red arrows: real dD/dx at step 25 of our run.

G then changes its weights θ so that its outputs move that way.

UPDATE G, HOLD D FIXED

G step: lock D's weights, keep the wire




```
D.requires_grad_(False)                    # lock D's weights, keep the path
loss_G = bce(D(G(torch.randn(B, zdim))), ones)   # fresh fakes, no detach
opt_G.zero_grad(); loss_G.backward(); opt_G.step(); D.requires_grad_(True)
```

THE MOST COMMON GAN BUG

Freezing is not detaching

detach(): cut the wire



the gradient stops at the cut: G learns nothing

requires_grad_(False): lock D's weights, keep the wire

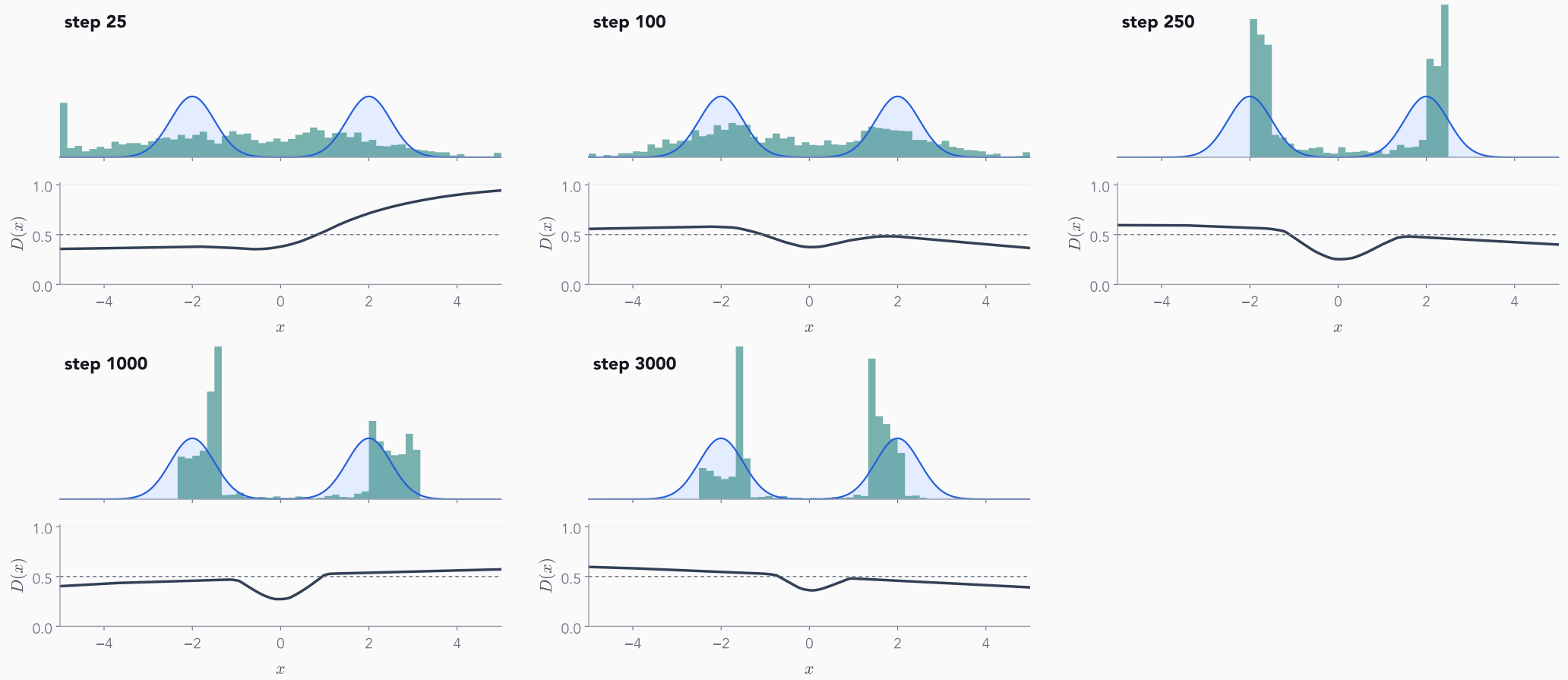


D's weights stay put; G still learns

> Detach the fake in the G step and loss_G still prints a number, but G never learns. Silent failure.

ALTERNATE THE TWO STEPS 3,000 TIMES

Watch the game on the toy data



By step 3,000 the fakes cover both bumps, and D(x) is near 0.5 wherever the data is: it can no longer tell.

THE TEXTBOOK FORMULA

A two-player minimax game

$$\min_{G} \max_{D} \; \mathbb{E}_{x \sim p_{\text{data}}} \big[\log D(x) \big] \; + \; \mathbb{E}_{z \sim p(z)} \big[\log \big(1 - D(G(z)) \big) \big]$$

D maximises: high D on real data, low D on fakes. This is our $-\mathcal{L}_D$.

G minimises: only the second term involves G. It wants $D(G(z))$ high.

With a perfect D, G's best move is $p_G = p_{\text{data}}$ (Goodfellow et al. 2014). Real training, with finite networks and steps, has no such guarantee.

Differentiate both with respect to D's logit a

$$D = \text{sigmoid}(a), \qquad \frac{dD}{da} = D\,(1 - D)$$

minimax: minimise $\log(1 - D)$

$$\frac{d}{da}\log(1 - D) = \frac{-D(1 - D)}{1 - D} = -D$$

$$D = 0.01 : \quad -0.01$$

non-saturating: minimise $-\log D$

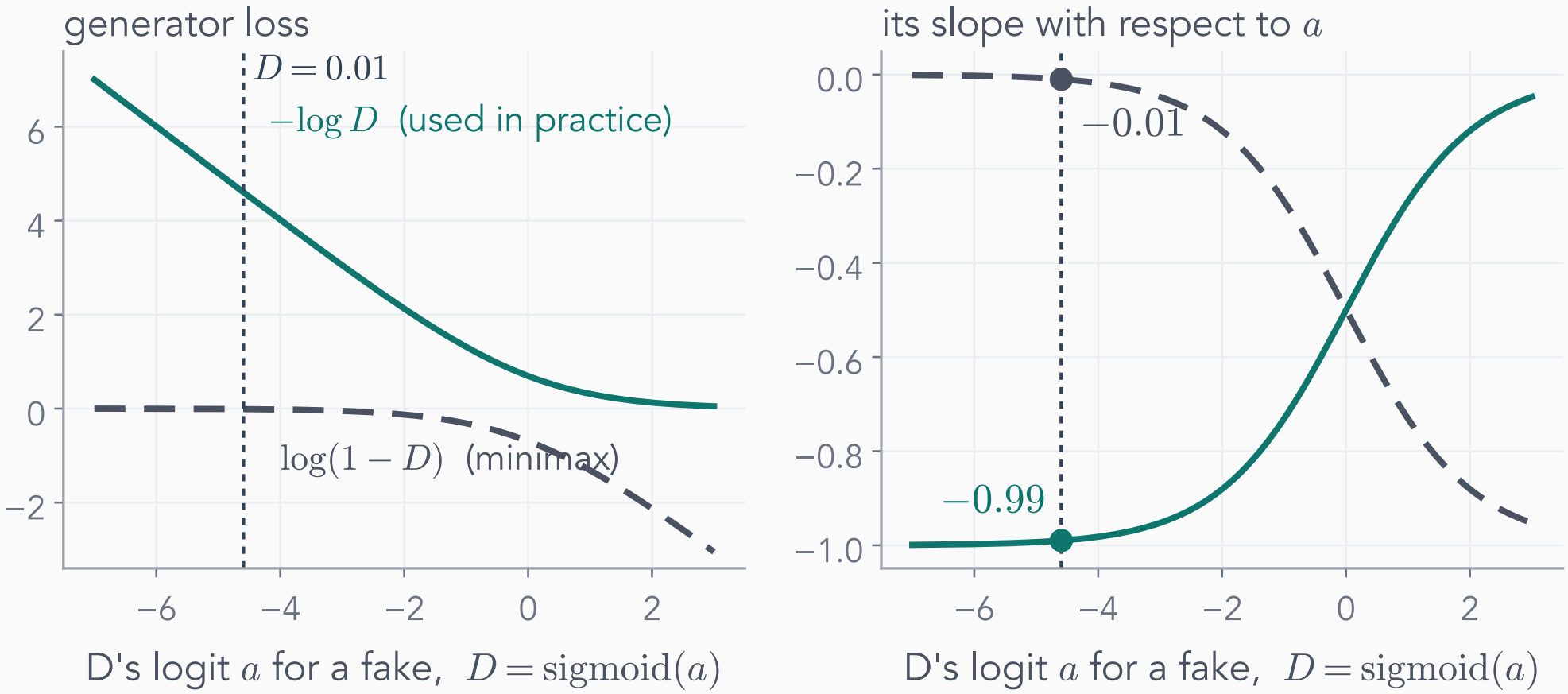
$$\frac{d}{da}\big(-\log D\big) = \frac{-D(1 - D)}{D} = D - 1$$

$$D = 0.01 : \quad -0.99$$

> **Early in training D easily rejects fakes, so $D \approx 0$: the minimax slope vanishes, the non-saturating one does not.**

WHY THE CODE USES A DIFFERENT GENERATOR LOSS

Early on, the minimax loss gives G almost no signal



When D easily spots a fake ($D = 0.01$): slope -0.01 for $\log(1 - D)$, slope -0.99 for $-\log D$. Same goal, a 99× stronger push.

THE COMPLETE UPDATE

One GAN iteration in code

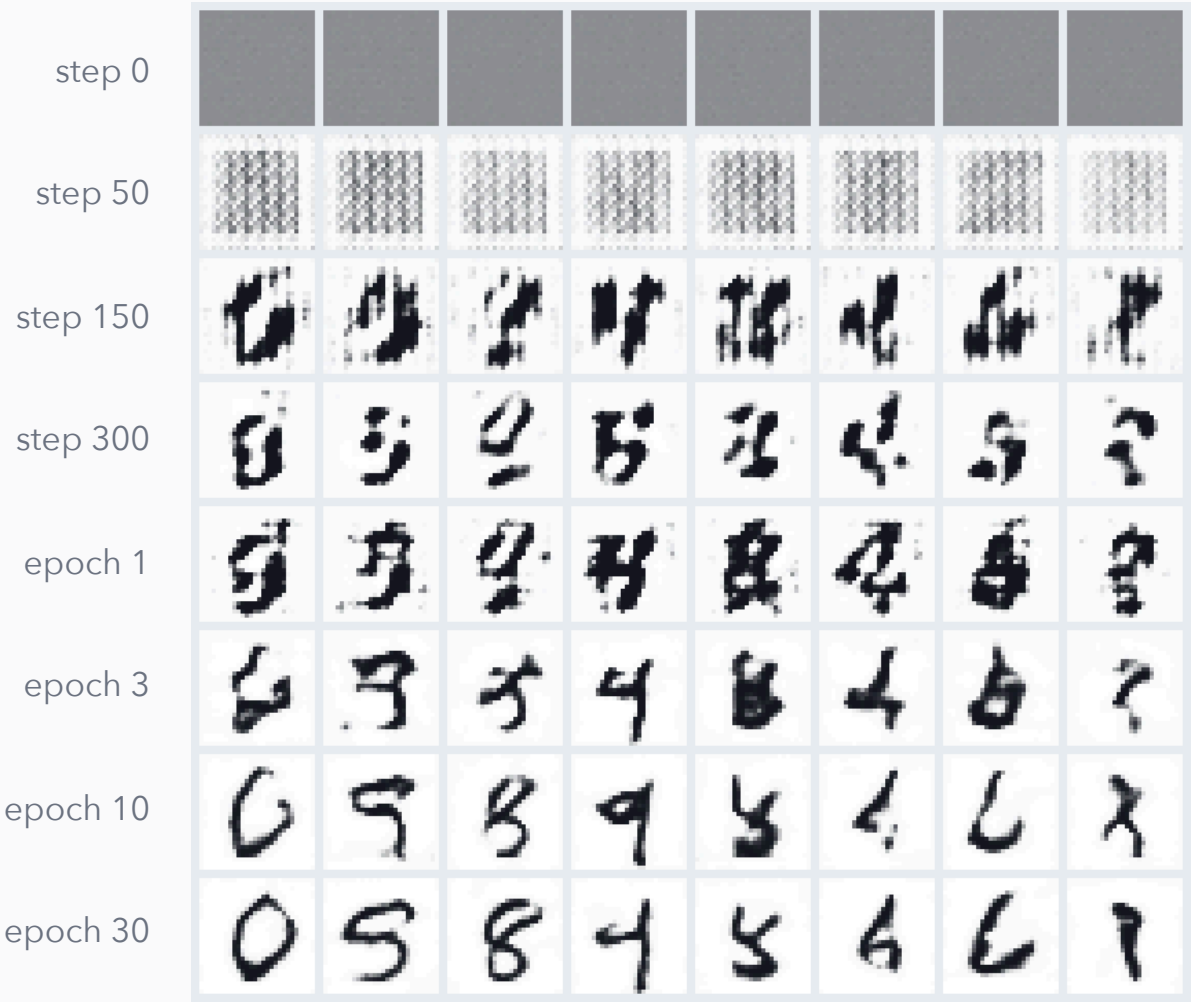
```
# ---- D step: real → 1, fake → 0, G receives nothing
fake = G(torch.randn(B, zdim))
loss_D = bce_logits(D(real), ones) + bce_logits(D(fake.detach()), zeros)
opt_D.zero_grad(); loss_D.backward(); opt_D.step()

# ---- G step: fresh fakes, D's weights locked, gradient flows through D
D.requires_grad_(False)
loss_G = bce_logits(D(G(torch.randn(B, zdim))), ones)
opt_G.zero_grad(); loss_G.backward(); opt_G.step()
D.requires_grad_(True)
```

Exactly this function trained the 1-D GAN and the MNIST GAN. Only G and D differ.

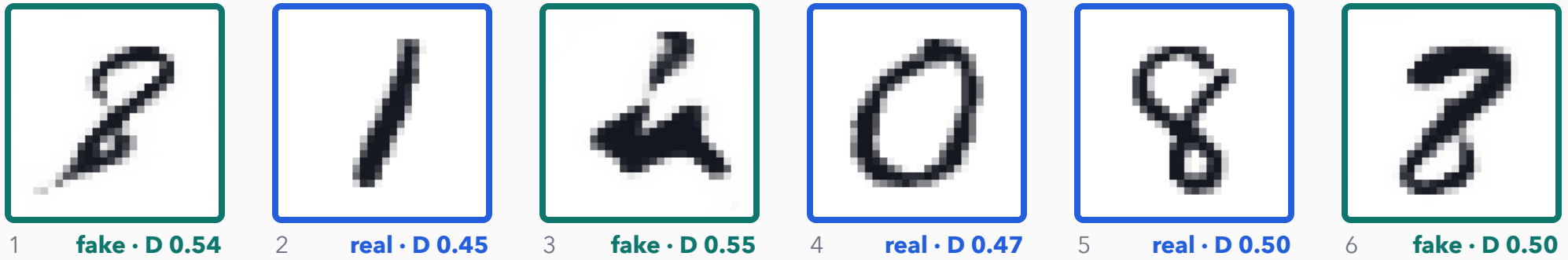
ON MNIST: THE SAME 8 CODES, THROUGH TRAINING

Watch the samples, not the loss



BACK TO THE VOTE

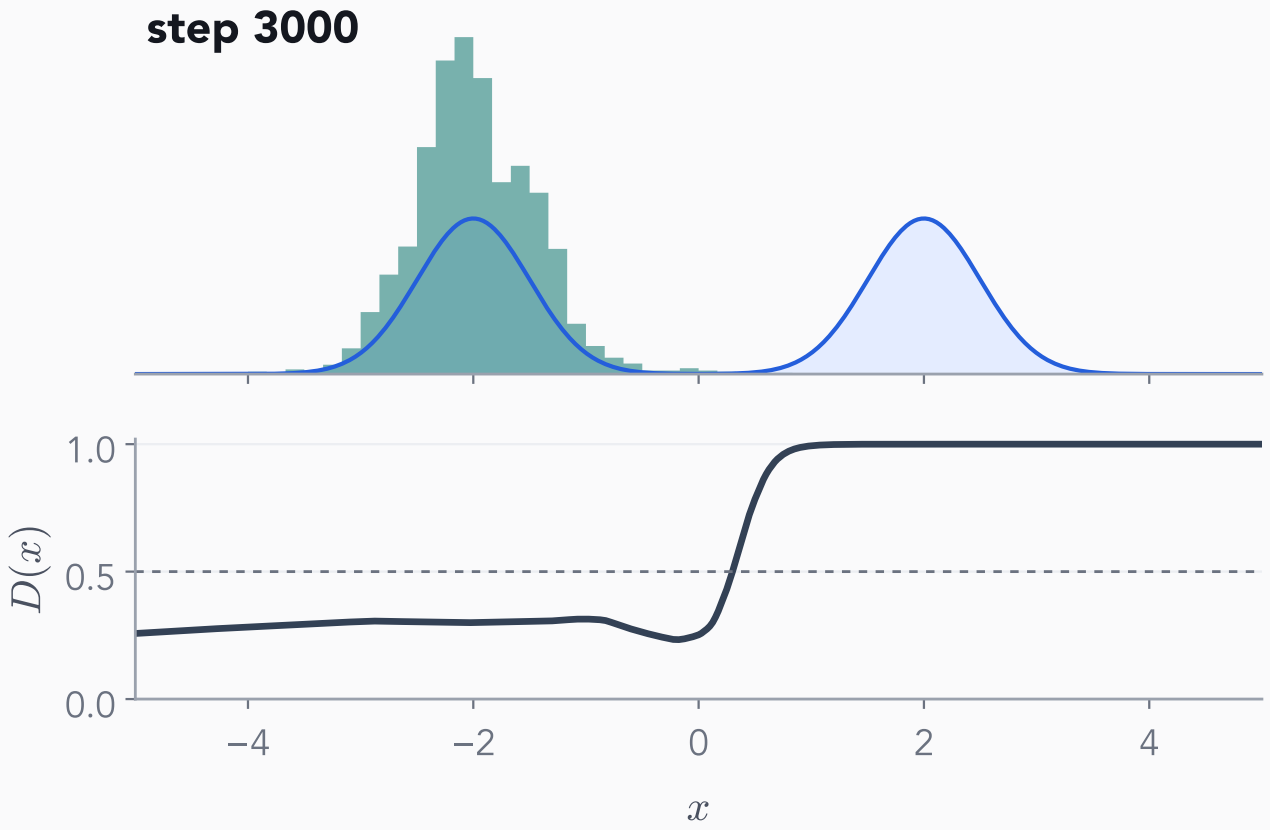
Which were real, and what did our discriminator think?



> Our trained D gives every tile between 0.39 and 0.55. At the end of training it can barely tell either.

THE CLASSIC FAILURE

Mode collapse: perfect samples of only one kind



Same data, same training loop, but G has only 4 hidden units per layer.

After 3,000 steps: 95% of samples sit on bump A, 0% on bump B.

Every sample looks real. Bump B is never generated. Picking your favourite samples would never reveal it.

Like the reverse-KL fit: commit to one mode and ignore the rest.

SO HOW DO YOU KNOW IT WORKED?

The loss curves cannot tell these two runs apart

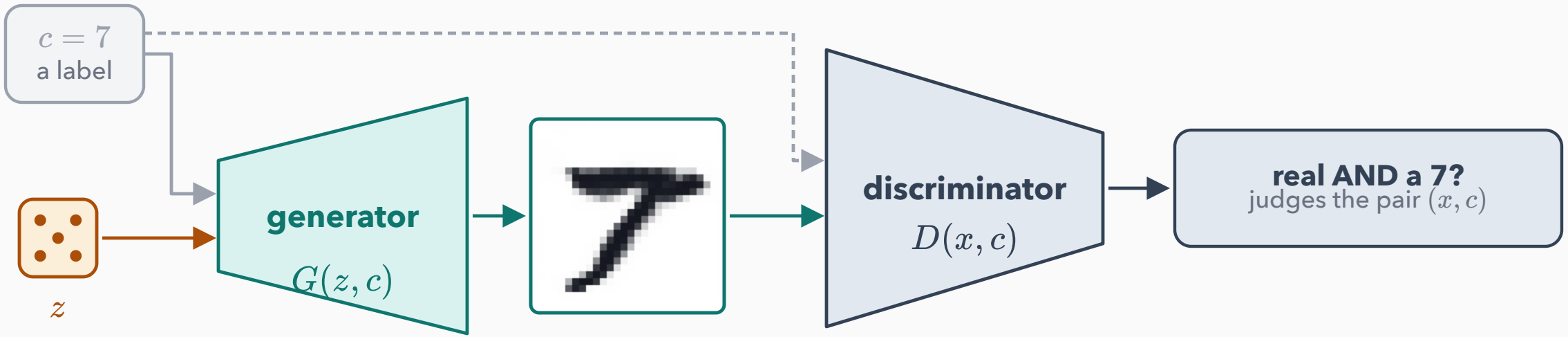




> **Both curves go flat. Only the samples show that one run lost half the data. Always look at samples, from fixed z, across training.**

BACK TO THE SHOES

Conditioning: tell both players what you want

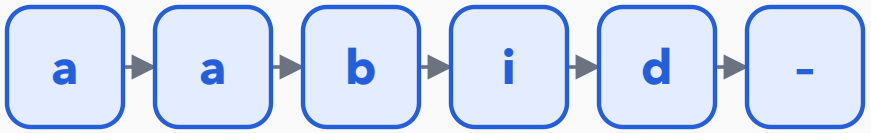


> If D never sees c, G can ignore the request and still fool D. pix2pix conditions on a whole sketch instead of a label.

THREE WAYS TO GENERATE

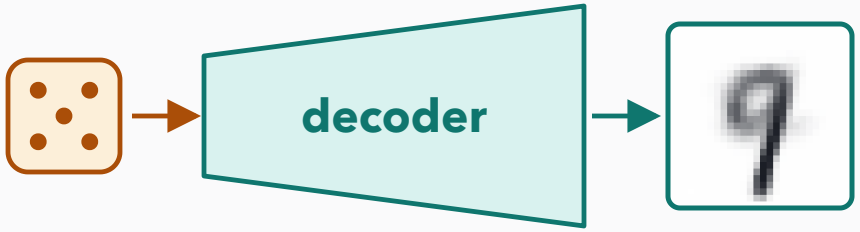
Same goal, three different training signals

autoregressive
one token at a time



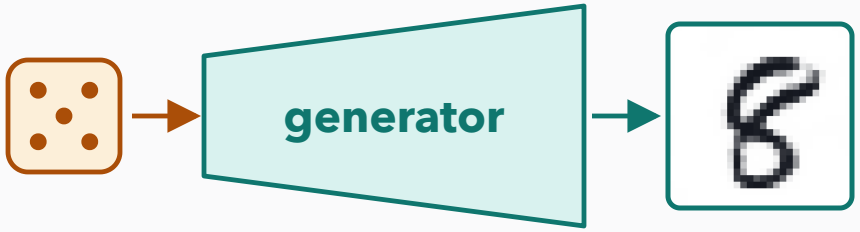
exact likelihood
slow sampling

VAE
random z, decode once



trained on the ELBO
tends to blur

GAN
random z, generate once



trained against a judge
may miss modes

RETURN TO THE OPENING

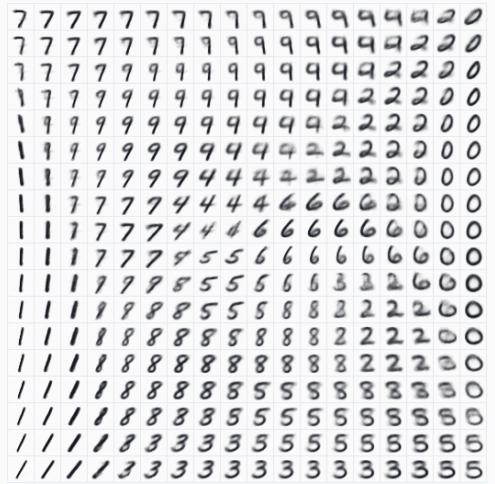
What you can now explain



a much larger GAN: z → face. Same two-step game, a cleverer G.



a conditional GAN: D judges (sketch, photo) pairs, plus an L1 term.



our VAE: every code in $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$ decodes to a digit, thanks to recon + KL.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

Three exit questions

1. To generate a new digit with a trained VAE, which parts of the network do you use?

   The prior and the decoder only: $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$, then decode. The encoder is for training.

2. Two different KL divergences appear in the VAE story. What does each compare, and which one is in the loss?

   $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{prior})$ is in the loss (6.97 for our 3). $\mathrm{KL}(q \,\|\, \text{true posterior})$ is the gap between the ELBO and $\log p_\theta(x)$ (0.61).

3. In the G step, D's weights are frozen. How does G still get a gradient?

   Freezing stops D's weights from updating, but the gradient still flows through D's input back into G. Only `detach()` would cut it.

NEXT LECTURE

What if we generate by removing noise, a little at a time?



our 3 → add a little Gaussian noise, again and again → pure noise

> **Adding noise is easy and gives free training pairs. Can a network learn to undo one small step, then walk all the way back from pure noise?**

APPENDIX

Derivations for reference

The optimal discriminator and its link to the Jensen–Shannon divergence. (The Gaussian KL and the ELBO gap are now derived in the main slides.)

APPENDIX C

The optimal discriminator

For fixed G, maximise $\int p_{\text{data}}(x) \log D(x) + p_G(x) \log(1 - D(x))\, dx$ pointwise in $D(x)$:

$$D^*(x) = \frac{p_{\text{data}}(x)}{p_{\text{data}}(x) + p_G(x)}$$

Substituting back:

$$V(D^*, G) = -\log 4 + 2\,\mathrm{JS}(p_{\text{data}} \,\|\, p_G)$$

So with a perfect D, G minimises the Jensen–Shannon divergence, which is 0 only when $p_G = p_{\text{data}}$, where $D^* = \frac{1}{2}$ everywhere. Idealised: real D and G are finite networks trained for finitely many steps.

FURTHER READING

Where to go next

- Lilian Weng, *From Autoencoder to Beta-VAE* and *From GAN to WGAN* (lilianweng.github.io)
- Jaan Altosaar, *Tutorial: what is a variational autoencoder?*: the neural-network and probability views side by side
- Kingma & Welling, *Auto-Encoding Variational Bayes*, arXiv 1312.6114
- Goodfellow et al., *Generative Adversarial Nets*, arXiv 1406.2661
- Stanford CS236 notes on VAEs and GANs (deepgenerativemodels.github.io)
- This lecture's code: `scripts/train_models.py` (all models) and `scripts/make_figures.py` (every number on the slides)